The Day The Sun Vanished

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/36554392.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F, Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Character:
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Modern AU, All Human, no powers, Post-Apocalypse, sorta - Freeform, surviving the end of the world, Alien Invasion, Horrorish, Sci-Fi, Scary stuff sometimes, Angst, Hurt/Comfort, Angst with a Happy Ending, yes everything I write has a happy ending, minor appearances from other characters probably

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The Day The Sun Vanished

by catrasredemption (dimensionhoppingrose)

Summary

It was dark when Adora woke up.

That didn’t mean much — Adora woke up at five a.m. or noon, and nowhere in between. She assumed it was five a.m. when she opened her eyes, at least until she reached for her phone and saw that it was twelve-thirty in the afternoon.

What?

OR

The entire world has gone dark, and all anyone can do now is try to survive.

OR

End of the world AU based on TheSunVanished on Twitter.

Notes

So this is something I've never tried before and I'm a little nervous, but.... *shrug* let's see what we can do I guess. Like the summary says, this is based on TheSunVanished on Twitter. I know it's a little weird, but give it a chance?

Lost

Day Zero

It was dark when Adora woke up.

That didn't mean much — Adora woke up at five a.m. or noon, and nowhere in between. She assumed it was five a.m. when she opened her eyes, at least until she reached for her phone and saw that it was twelve-thirty in the afternoon.

What?

Adora checked her phone, then the window, then her phone again. It wasn't cloudy. It wasn't even night time. It was *black*. The streetlights were off. There were no lights on in any of the houses around her. She tried her bedroom light, which worked, but it felt weird to keep it on. She immediately turned it off again.

And her phone rang. She checked the caller ID and answered.

"Catra?"

"*About freaking time you woke up. I was starting to to think you were dead.*" She could recognize the terror in her best friend's voice under the heavy sarcasm.

"Are you okay?"

"*Yeah, I'm great. Weather's awesome, isn't it?*"

"Not sure, think the sky is broken," Adora shot back, slightly annoyed. "Not the time, Catra!"

Catra was quiet for a long moment. "*Sorry*," she said finally, voice low. "*I've been freaking out*."

"Yeah." Adora looked out the window, to where she would *usually* be able to see Catra's bedroom window. "Why's your light off?"

"*I don't know. It just feels wrong with everything being so dark outside. Have your parents texted or anything?*"

Adora put her phone on speaker so she could check her texts and call logs. "No," she said quietly. "What about your mom?"

Catra snorted. "*She probably caused this somehow and you know it.*"

"I mean… okay, probably." Adora scrubbed her eyes. "Do you think it's safe to go outside?"

"*Hell no. Let's just… sit it out and wait. The sun will probably come back, right?*"

"Um… right." Adora wasn't sure. Catra didn't sound entirely sure herself. "Well, we still have electricity, so we should charge up everything while we still can. Make sure our phones are full, and any battery rods and stuff. Check wifi, maybe we can skype to talk without burning our phone batteries."

"*Right, yeah. Let me get laptop. I'll call you in a minute if I can*."

"All right."

Adora ended the call and grabbed her laptop, booting it up. The wifi signal was strong, to her relief. She opened Skype and called Catra, who was already online. It took seconds for Catra's worried expression to fill her screen.

"*Hey*."

"Hey." Adora gave her a weak smile. "You okay?"

"*Yeah. I mean, it could be worse. I could be stuck with my mother*." Adora laughed, mostly out of relief. Catra half-smiled. "*Sorry. I know you like your parents. Have you tried calling them?*"

"No," Adora admitted, looking at her phone. She was hoping they would call her, but clearly that wasn't happening. Catra watched

Adora hit call on her mother's name and put the phone to her ear. It rang several times before going to voicemail. She tried her dad next. Same thing. Finally she texted them both to call her and let her know they were okay.

"*I'm sure they're fine*," Catra said, doing her best to sound convincing. Adora took a deep breath and smiled.

"Yeah. Come on, we're going to the kitchen."

"*Why*?"

Adora unplugged her laptop to carry it downstairs, stopping in the hall closet to grab a couple duffel bags. "I don't… really want to be on the first floor if I can help it. I'm not sure why, it just doesn't feel right. Think I'm going to make sure the doors are locked and bring as much food and stuff back upstairs as possible."

She left her laptop on the table while she worked. Her parents, thankfully, had stocked the house up before they left, so she had plenty of food. Shuffling from the laptop informed her Catra was probably doing the same thing.

"*What about cooking? And refrigerated foods?*"

Adora shrugged, hauling the beach cooler into the kitchen. "If I get desperate I can come back down and cook things. I just… I don't know. Don't feel safe?"

"*I get that, but other than the whole 'sun disappearing' thing, there isn't really a* reason *to feel unsafe, right? And we can talk to each other right now. Maybe we should save shelf-stable stuff for when we're really freaked out, and use everything else in the mean time*."

It was a bit backwards, but Adora *did* follow the logic. "Run through the perishables and cooking stuff first so we can save the shelf-stable stuff for when the aliens come marching down the street?"

"*Don't!*" Catra's voice cracked. "*That's not funny!*"

"Sorry. But you're right, that's a good idea. Guess I'll make lunch while I'm down here."

She popped a frozen pizza into the oven to cook while she worked. Every now and again, she and Catra would call suggestions to each other — "Grab any fresh fruit," "Fill up all the water bottles you have," etc. — but for the most part they were silent. Just *having* Catra there felt good, though. Safe. Even if she was across the street. Even if that felt like a million miles away.

"*Have you tried the TV?*" Catra asked.

"No. You?"

"*I fell asleep with it on last night, it was still broadcasting when I woke up around six. Every non-news channel had an emergency broadcast going, and the news was talking about everyone already rioting and shit. Everything went dark a couple hours ago, though*."

Adora frowned, slipping into the living room to turn on the TV. Sure enough, nothing was showing even though it showed that the cable was still connected.

"That's weird," she said slowly, returning to the kitchen. "What about the internet?"

"*Every new site is down, but social media is somehow still going strong*." Adora couldn't see Catra's face, but she knew her friend was rolling her eyes. "*Twitter and Facebook are like cockroaches. They'll survive the apocalypse.*"

"So *they're* the new source of news? Great."

"*Seriously. Got in touch with Scorpia, though. She's holding up with her girlfriend over in Plumeria. No sign of Entrapta, but I'm sure she has some emergency kill switch on all of her stuff for this*

kind of situation. She's probably already setting up her own entire network."

"Fingers crossed." The oven dinged. Adora went to get her pizza out. "Oh, how's Melog?"

"*Has yet to notice this minor inconvenience. He's up sleeping in my room. Glad I just got food for him*." Catra paused for a moment before continuing. "*What do you think is happening downtown right now? And where are all our neighbors?*"

Adora peeked out the window again. Still no house lights or any movement. "I don't know. Make sure your doors are locked."

"*Adora, I've been home alone for three days. I've unlocked the doors* once *for a pizza delivery and bring a baseball bat everywhere I go*."

Normally Adora would've said Catra's paranoia was slightly unhealthy. But she was grateful for it at that moment. "A weapon is a good idea, actually. I should get my sword."

"*You absolutely should not. You don't even know how to use it."*

"I'll figure it out if something tries to break in."

"*And if you hurt yourself? I don't think we're getting you to a hospital, dummy*."

Okay, *that* was a good point, as much as Adora hated to admit it. "*Fine*. My pocket knife?"

"*Better. Bet you wish you'd stuck with lacrosse or softball, huh?*"

"I didn't realize I was planning my future around what sport would have better end-of-the-world equipment."

"*Jeez, Adora. Get it together*."

Adora rolled her eyes, grabbing a knife to cut her pizza. "Come on, let's just get stuff back upstairs."

It took two trips, and another stop in the closet to get the emergency bag and first-aid kit, but finally Adora was back in her room, bookcase pushed in front of her door. Just in case. She plugged her laptop back in and settled down to eat. Catra was playing with Melog, who still seemed mostly undisturbed by everything. Adora's phone was completely silent. She tried not to pay too much attention to it. Her parents were probably fine. It was fine.

"Catra?"

"*Hmn?*"

"This… This is going to fix itself, right? I mean… the sun has to come back. Right?"

Catra was quiet for too long — the same quiet she had been when they were little, and Adora had asked about the bruises on her arm, or why she didn't have a lunch. The same quiet that followed a teacher asking why she had pushed Lonnie off the swing, why her homework wasn't done, why her report card wasn't signed. The same quiet that followed after she hit a kid for making fun of her "mutant eyes."

"*Yeah*," she said finally, lying with confidence. "*Of course it will. This is probably just some weird all-day eclipse or something. I'm sure things will be back to normal tomorrow*."

Adora let out a long breath, taking comfort in her best friend's lies. "Yeah. I'm sure you're right."

Day One

She was *not* right, of course.

It was disorienting to wake up to the darkness while the clock read nine a.m. Adora yawned, sitting up and looking at her laptop

screen. She and Catra had fallen asleep on cam together, comforted by the presence of another person. Catra was already awake, lying on her back, staring at her phone. Melog was asleep on her chest.

"*Hey, Adora*."

"Hey," Adora said quietly, shifting to lie on her side and give the screen more attention. "Any news?"

"*Nope. All official news outlets are black. Twitter and Facebook are going crazy, though, so if this is some kind of cover up, whoever's in charge is doing a bad job*."

Adora frowned. "What do you mean *cover up*?"

"*Seriously?"* Catra scoffed. *"Keep up. I know you're not that stupid. You don't think it's a* little *weird that every news station in the entire country isn't airing twenty four/seven about the literally the biggest event to ever happen in the history of the world? The* sun *is* gone*. Every scientist should be fighting to death to get on TV for their fifteen minutes of fame. Conspiracy theorists should be calling hotlines non-stop. Some weirdo billionaire should have already bought a shit-ton of airtime to advertise their brand new Mars vacation rocket. But there's* nothing*. All the news channels are down, all their websites are dead, even that bullshit guy who screams about gay frogs is gone. And calling his crap news is generous at best.*"

"Okay, well when you put it like that…"

Catra shook her head, scrolling on her phone. "*So all the news is cut off, but black sun has been trending on Instagram for like fifteen hours. People started accounts yesterday just to take pictures of the sky and they have over a million followers already. Nothing is stopping the world from* talking *about it.*"

"But there's still no news," Adora finished quietly. "Yeah. That's weird." She looked at her phone, calling her parents again. This time the phones went straight to voicemail. She didn't bother

trying to text. “Maybe I should just take a chance and run over to you…”

“*No way. We still don’t know what’ll happen if you go outside. What if the dark is like, a bunch of little creatures that are waiting to eat you?*”

Adora raised an eyebrow. “Wasn’t that the plot of that nerdy British show you watched last year?”

“*Okay first off, it’s not nerdy, second, it was just two episodes, and third, that’s not the point*.”

“*Fine*.” Adora huffed. “I won’t try to go out in the dark in case there are scary shadow monsters.”

“*I’m ignoring the sarcasm and just going to say thank you for listening to your clearly smarter friend*.”

The silence was terrible and eerie. Adora looked out the window, grimacing at the darkness. “What about the moon? And the stars?”

She had tried not to look outside much yesterday and hadn’t really even noticed when day turned to night. Catra shook her head. “*Nothing last night. Which is a shame because there’s zero light pollution right now as far as I can tell. We could probably see the Milky Way.”*

“Maybe it was cloudy?”

“*Maybe*.” The lie was a little weaker than it had been the night before. “*We’ll have to check tonight.*”

Day Four

Electricity and wifi were still holding out, so that was good. Adora made sure her phone and any other necessary accessories were fully charged, and stayed on the call with Catra at all times. It

dropped once or twice because Skype was just like that, but Catra always immediately called back.

"I wish I had a pet," Adora said longingly, watching Melog walk over Catra's back. He was starting to realize something Weird was going on, and he didn't like it.

"*Come borrow this one. Melog,* off*.*" Catra hissed, a high-pitched noise that made the cat jump and scramble away. She acted like he annoyed her, but Adora knew damn well she'd be devastated if anything happened to him. He was her second best friend.

(First best friend if Adora was being particularly annoying.)

"Do you remember any of the Morse code we learned at the survival camp in sixth grade?" Adora asked. Catra blinked, staring at her in confusion.

"*A little. Why?*"

"I was thinking maybe we could use a flashlight and Morse code to get a neighbor's attention. See how everyone else is doing, you know?"

"*Your depending on* any *of our neighbors knowing Morse code. Also I think a lot of people were out of town on vacation this week — every driveway I can see from my room is empty. And do you* really *want to draw attention to your house with a flashing light?*"

"I… I don't know. Do you think attention is bad?"

"*I don't know. It's just a feeling I have. The electricity is fine, right? But there are no lights on* anywhere*. Why?*"

"Well, why are you keeping yours off?"

"*Because I don't want anyone else to know I'm here*." The confession was quiet and surprisingly vulnerable. They were so close to each other, but so isolated that across the street may as

well have been across the country. "*Something* bad *is happening. Maybe it's better no one thinks we're here*."

Adora didn't disagree. She hadn't turned on any lights in the house since the first day, because any light stronger than a flashlight felt taboo in this total darkness.

"Yeah. Maybe you're right."

Day Eight

"*Adora. Adora!"*

Adora jerked awake with a muffled "Huh?" raising her head to blink at her computer screen. Catra was a little too close to her camera, wide-eyed and clearly terrified. Adora jumped back, covering her mouth automatically to stifle a surprised yelp.

"What?" she hissed through her fingers.

"*Someone's outside*."

The whispered words sent ice through Adora's veins. She stared at Catra for a long moment, heart beating furiously in her chest, looking for some sign that this was just a prank. But Catra was scared. She wouldn't fake that just for a bad joke.

Adora reached for her pocket knife, slipping off her bed and to the window. She very carefully split the blinds to peek outside. And sure enough, someone was there. A tall, shadowy figure standing right in the middle of the street, perfectly between their houses.

"Oh." Adora leaned back against the wall, sliding down it and curling up. They hadn't seen anyone since the day the sun had vanished. Who could possibly be out there *now?* "Catra? Is your door barricaded?"

"*Yeah*." Even she couldn't keep the shakiness out of her voice.

"Okay. Good."

They sat in silence for the rest of the night, neither daring to sleep.

Day Eleven

The person had left eventually, but that made Adora feel worse, if she was honest. They could be anywhere. They could be at the back door right now. They—

Melog meowed loudly, and Adora shrieked.

"*What the fuck*?!" Catra yelped, jarred out of her trance-like stupor. "*Adora*?!"

"I'm fine," Adora squeaked, blushing. "Sorry."

Catra groaned, dropping back onto her bed. "*Christ*."

They stared at their separate ceilings, content in the silence for a moment. "Maybe we should go," Adora said after a minute.

"*Go where*?"

"I don't know. Anywhere. I don't think it's safe here."

"*The sun is gone.* No where *is safe.*"

Adora sighed loudly. "Yeah. Probably not. We can't just stay here forever, though. What happens when we run out of food?"

"*I'm not sure. We could try the city, I guess? I bet everything is looted already, though.*"

"I mean, we have to do *something* for food. Have you seen any any birds or anything since… this started?"

"*Wow, slow down, we haven't gotten into nature survival yet*."

"No, it's just something that I thought of." Adora frowned, sitting up and looking at her blind-covered window.

"*I haven't really looked out the window much since, you know, the other night.*"

"Same." Adora stood, making her way to the window and peeking through the blinds. It was just dark. No mysterious figures. No birds in the sky. No critters in the yard. The air was completely and eerily still.

"What are we so afraid of?"

"*You mean besides the obvious?*" Catra asked dryly.

"But being too afraid to even cross the street? That's not like us."

"*Nothing about this is exactly normal*."

"Still." Adora narrowed her eyes. "I'm going to do it. I think it'll be safer for both of us if—"

A faint light flashed through the skies.

Adora thought she'd imagined it, and just froze, still staring out the window, eyes wide. But then it happened again — a flash of green light momentarily bathing the street in a sickening hue. Adora screamed, jolting back from the window and tripping over her feet, crashing to the ground. Her heartbeat was loud in her ears, drowning out the sound of Catra calling her name.

"—'*dora? Adora! What the fuck was that? Are you okay?*"

"Yeah." Adora did her best to swallow the fear, dragging herself onto her bed and collapsing in front of her laptop. "Yeah, I'm okay. You… You saw that too, right?"

"*Yup.*" Catra's expression was carefully neutral as she did her best not to look shaken. She was trying to be brave for Adora, just like when they watched stupid horror movies. "*Still wanna come over?*"

"I… I don't think so, no."

Day Sixteen

A scream shattered the silent air.

Adora jolted awake with a gasp, head snapping around. "Catra?" she asked stupidly, reaching for her laptop. The Skype call had ended. The scream hadn't come from the laptop.

It had come from across the street.

Adora flew to her window, ripping the blinds open. Everything was dark, same as always. Everything except the faint green light coming from Catra's house.

"Catra!"

There was no hesitation, no second thought. She whirled away from the window, grabbing her sheathed sword from the floor next to the bed, shoving the bookcase away from her door, and running out.

Catra, Catra, Catra. It was the only thing in her mind, repeated over and over like a prayer. *Catra*. She took the stairs two at a time. *Catra*. She banked a sharp left at the intersection of the living room and kitchen, eyes fixed on the front door. *Catra*. She threw the door open and ran outside for the first time in over two weeks.

The green light had faded, but the door was still open. Adora ran right in, ready to draw her sword, when something sharp slashed against her ankle. Ankle? Was someone on the floor with a knife? Something was yowling…

Oh.

"Melog!"

The cat had latched on to Adora's pants, snarling and growling as he tried to bite through the fabric. "Melog, get *off*!" Adora shook her leg, trying to throw him off. "It's *me*, you dummy, stop—"

Rapidly approaching footsteps caught Adora's attention, and she whirled, jerking her sword up just in time to block a swinging baseball bat. Catra reared back again, wild-eyed, preparing to swing.

"*Catra*!"

Melog was still hissing and spitting as he bit into Adora's increasingly bloody ankle, but Catra finally stopped, breathing hard, staring through Adora rather than seeing her. "It's me," Adora assured her, holding one hand up in surrender. "It's me, see? Look."

The bat clattered to the floor, and Catra threw herself at Adora, slamming into her hard enough to knock her back a few steps. Adora immediately dropped the sword and wrapped her in a tight hug, nearly lifting her off the ground. The movement finally shook off Melog, who tumbled to the ground and darted under the couch.

"What happened?" Adora dared to ask after a moment. Catra shuddered, arms tightening.

"I — I don't — There were — They — They—"

She shook her head, hiding her face in Adora's neck. "Okay, okay," Adora murmured, brushing her hair back. "I've got you, it's all right. Don't worry."

She carefully walked Catra to the closest chair and sat, pulling her into her lap. She watched the door over Catra's shoulder while she waited for her friend to calm down. Everything was dark and still again.

"There… There was someone in the house," Catra finally whispered, voice thick. "I didn't see… it was all dark, but there were eyes… really, really green eyes. They were glowing. I…"

She shivered, burrowing closer to Adora. "I've got you," Adora repeated, fingers still tangled in Catra's hair. "Did they hurt you?"

Catra shook her head. “I hit them.”

Adora laughed breathlessly. “Good job.”

That got her a weak chuckle in return. “Adora?”

“Mmmm?”

“I don’t want to stay here.”

“Same.” Adora gave her one final squeeze before pulling back to meet Catra’s tear-filled gaze. “Let’s get as much as we can together and go back to my place. Okay?”

Catra nodded, half looking over her shoulder. “Melog…?”

He was still under the couch, hissing. “I’ll get stuff together,” Adora corrected. “You get him out from under the couch.”

“Don’t forget his food.”

“I won’t, don’t worry.”

It took some coaxing and a few treats, but Catra finally fished Melog out, wrapping him in a blanket. His fur was on end, pupils shrunken to to pinpricks as he scanned the room for danger.

“Shit,” Catra said when she saw Adora’s ankle. “He really got you.”

“Good little guard cat.”

Catra got Melog tucked into his carrier, then shouldered a few bags of supplies and grabbed her baseball bat. Adora joined her with a few more bags, and they left the house together, Catra closing the door behind her.

“You left your door open.”

“Yeaaaaaah.” Adora winced, rubbing the back of her head. “I was in a hurry.”

They left their stuff in a pile by the front door and kept their weapons to search the house. It was empty, but Adora still felt uneasy as she closed and locked the door. Melog had fallen asleep in his carrier, already over his traumatic experience. Lucky him.

Adora scoped out the house one more time while Catra carried everything upstairs. She was sitting on the bed, carefully brushing Melog, when Adora joined her, closing the door.

"You okay?"

Catra nodded, focusing on Melog's fur. It was, Adora knew, a stress reaction. She brushed her hair, or Melog's fur, when she needed a distraction.

"You're safe now." Adora sat with her, resting a hand on her shoulder.

"Yeah. I think I'm just gonna… sit awake for a bit. But you should get some sleep. It's late."

"Is it?" Their sleep schedules were officially dead at this point. There was no day or night when there was no sun or moon. But Adora could tell Catra wanted to be left alone, so she respected that the best she could, lying back on her bed to play on her phone. "I found a weird Twitter account," Catra said after a few minutes, looking up. Her gaze was slightly distant, clouded with the remnants of panic.

"Only one?"

"A different kind of weird. Look up TheRebellion, all one word."

Adora did as she was told, and brought up a Twitter page with a simple description: *We won't go into the light*.

"That's dramatic."

"Start reading."

The account was littered with pictures of flashing green lights, odd ships, shadowy figures, and between all that were calls to arms, talking about alien invasions and taking back their world. Humanity, she thought with faint amusement. It never gave up.

Day Twenty-One

Adorkable

You think you can fight whatever this is?

TheRebellion

We know we can. We just have to try

Adorkable

Do you really know HOW to fight them?

TheRebellion

We're figuring it out. We've learned a lot about them already

"You still talking to Sparkles?" Catra asked, rolling onto her stomach to watch Adora, who was typing on her phone.

"Yeah. Not exactly the name I'd choose if I wanted to be a great Rebellion leader."

"Oh yeah? What *would* you choose?"

Adora flopped back on the bed, thinking for a moment. "She-Ra. It just sounds cool."

"It definitely *does not* sound cool," Catra said with a snort.

"Does too!"

Adorkable

My friend and I are alone. Our parents weren't home when the disappeared. We've been seeing green lights and things in the streets

TheRebellion

You're going to get caught. It's amazing you haven't already

Adorkable

We don't have anywhere else to go

TheRebellion

We can help you. As long as you promise not to kill us

Adora laughed, startling Catra and Melog. "I think Sparkles is offering to let us join her rebellion."

"Really?" Catra sat up on her elbows. "What do you think?"

"I mean…" Adora looked around her room. "We can't stay here forever. I wish we could, it'd be easier, but eventually we're either going to need food or get smoked out. And maybe they really do have something going for them."

"Maybe." Catra frowned, looking at the ceiling. "When was the last time you got gas?"

"A few days before this started, but it's not like I've been going anywhere. And there are still cars around the neighborhood we can siphon from. I'm pretty sure there are some empty gas canisters in the garage."

"That might work, then. Where's this Rebellion hiding out?"

Adora looked back at her phone, typing up a message.

Adorkable

Where?

“Melog has to come with us,” Catra said, scritching Melog’s ears. “No matter what.”

“Of course. If Melog isn’t welcome, then it’s not a place we want to be in.”

Her phone dinged.

TheRebellion

Meet us on the edge of the Whispering Woods, outside of Plumeria

Adora switched over to the map app, looking up the Whispering Woods. “Two-day drive to meet them,” she said, holding her phone out to Catra. “What do you think?”

Catra leaned closer to look at the phone. “It’s worth trying, I guess? If it’s a bust, we can just keep driving. Wanna be a post-apocalyptic lesbian salvager with me?”

“Wow, that’s practically a proposal.”

Adorkable

It’s going to take some time for us to get things together and get there. I’ll keep you updated

Day Twenty-Six

Melog was yowling unhappily in the back seat. His carrier expanded on either side, giving him plenty of room, but he was still bundled up in a corner, crying like a child who had been denied dessert.

“You’ll be fine,” Catra chided him as she put a bowl of water into the carrier with him. Adora finished packing the trunk and closed it, looking around nervously. She still didn’t like being outside. “You taking first shift, or me?”

“I’ll take it.” Adora blew out a long breath, tugging her ponytail. “Come on, let’s get going.”

They climbed into the car, Adora messaged Sparkles to let her know they were heading out, then started the car. Her headlights were almost blinding in the darkness. “That’s unsettling.”

“Yeah.” Adora took a deep breath, drumming her fingers against the steering wheel. “Okay. Let’s go.”

She put the car in drive, and they were off.

Catra was glued to the window, watching the scenery — or what would have been scenery if it hadn’t been completely black. Adora went slow, keeping her eyes on the road, half expecting something to dart out in front of the car.

“There really is no wildlife,” she murmured, fingers tightening around the steering wheel.

“Nope.” Catra curled up in her seat, arms around her legs. “What do you think happened to them? There’s no way whatever this is just… just killed everything, right?”

“Maybe it’s all in hiding. Don’t animals have like, a danger sense? Like when cows all lie down in the field before thunderstorms?”

“I’d say that sounds stupid, but considering what we’re dealing with…” Catra shrugged, resting her head against the window. “Who knows. Maybe.”

Melog had gone silent in the backseat. Adora dared to look in the rearview mirror, and saw that he had fallen asleep. Lucky him.

“Have we considered what we’re going to do if Sparkles turns out to be a fifty-year-old dude trying to lure us out to the middle of nowhere?”

“You have your bat, I have my sword. We’ll be fine.”

"You're going to kill us both."

"Stop being so dramatic."

"I'll stop being dramatic when the sun comes back."

That was one way to end a conversation. They drove in silence for a bit before Catra leaned forward to start checking the radio. Everything was static.

"I guess no one wants to be DJ-ing rush hour," she said, grabbing Adora's phone and finding some music to put on in the background. "Imagine being an end-of-the world radio broadcaster. I think that's what I'd want my apocalypse job to be."

"*Really*?" Adora asked in disbelief. "You're not really the radio personality type."

"Excuse me?" Catra huffed in mock offense. "I have a *great* voice, thank you very much."

"It's definitely not your *voice* I'm worried about."

"Shut up." Catra shoved Adora's shoulder, and they laughed. "I guess radio would be a waste of my good looks, though."

"*Wow*, ego much?"

"It's not ego if it's true."

"Uh *huh*." Adora rolled her eyes, but the banter made her feel better. It was normal. It was easy. It was *them*. Adora and Catra, off on a drive to who knows where, whipping snarky remarks back and forth. It was almost easy to ignore everything outside the car that was definitely *not* normal.

Day Twenty-Nine

"This is freaky."

"Yeah."

They were parked near the entrance to a walking path into the Whispering Woods. It was dark, no sign of any other life. “This is where Sparkles said to meet them, right?”

Adora looked at her phone. “Yup, this is it. Come on.”

Catra looked doubtful, but she climbed out of the car with Adora, slowly approaching the woods, swinging a flashlight around. Adora followed, her sword hanging by her side.

“You’re going to kill us with that thing.”

“I am not—“

Something *twing*-ed, then hit the ground right in front of them. They screamed, jumping back, Adora bringing the sword up. Catra quickly scrambled away from her and shone the flashlight on the thing — an arrow.

“That’s far enough!”

The voice was definitely… higher pitched than Adora had been expecting. She wasn’t really sure if she’d suspected a man or a woman behind the account, but she had at least hoped for an adult — not the small, pink-haired, teenage girl who stepped out of the woods, with a taller black boy behind her wielding a bow. She swung her flashlight around to look at both of them.

“Turn around.”

“What?” Adora asked stupidly. The boy knocked another arrow into place, leveling it at them.

“Turn around!” the girl repeated, voice sharper. “And drop your weapons, now!”

Adora immediately released the sword, hands up, and turned obediently. “You too,” the girl said, presumably to Catra, who hadn’t moved.

"Now is *not* the time to be stubborn," Adora hissed. "They're going to shoot us with *arrows*. Just turn around."

Catra didn't answer. Her expression had gone blank. "Hey, are you ignoring me?" the girl demanded, sounding highly annoyed. "Turn *around*. Now."

"Catra, come *on*."

"Look, we're not going to actually shoot you—"

"Bow, don't *tell them that*!"

"But we need to see your neck. Please."

She still didn't turn. "Catra." Adora turned to her, ignoring the others now. "Stop, this isn't funny. Turn *around*."

She bowed her head, closing her eyes. "This could have been easy." Her voice was… flat. Disconnected. Emotionless in a way Adora had only ever heard in Ms. Weaver.

A green hue lit up the area.

Adora heard yelling, and movement, and something hit her hard in the temple. She felt a faint trickle of blood as she dropped, and the world went black.

"Damn it! Are they still tailing us?"

"I don't think so…"

Silence. except for familiar yowl of a cat. Melog.

Adora forced her eyes open.

She was lying in the back seat of the car as it rumbled along an empty road, staring at the ceiling. Her head was in someone's lap, she realized right as the boy leaned over to look at her.

“Hey, you okay? Also, do you know how to calm down the cat? He’s bitten me like three times.”

Adora blinked at him a few times, mind hazy. Melog was upset. They were in the car. Where…?

She gasped, shooting upright, ignoring the pounding in her head. “Catra!”

“She’s gone,” the girl in the driver’s seat said flatly.

“*What*? What do you mean *gone*? Did you leave her behind?!”

“We didn’t have a choice—“

“We have to go back!”

Adora jolted forward, trying to climb into the front and grab the wheel. The girl shrieked, jerking away instinctively, and the car spun, sending Adora crashing into the back again. The boy held her tight until they were back under control.

“What is *wrong* with you?!” the girl snapped. “You don’t *grab the wheel* when someone is driving!”

“You left my friend and *stole* my car and kidnapped me!”

“That’s a funny way of saying we saved your life!”

“Okay, okay,” the boy cut in, hands up. “Let’s try this again. I’m—“

“I want to go back,” Adora said sharply.

“We are *not* going back,” the girl informed her. “Your friend is *gone*, okay? They got her.”

“Who are *they*?”

“We call them the greens,” the boy spoke up. “It’s kind of their theme. Their lights are green, their eyes glow green—“

“This sounds like a terrible sci-fi movie.”

The girl laughed humorlessly. “The sun disappeared almost a *month* ago. We’re *passed* terrible sci-fi movie and going straight into post-apocalypse.”

Melog was still yowling. Adora reached over to scratch between his ears. The familiar hand quieted him a little. The girl was watching them in the rearview mirror.

“I can’t believe you brought your *cat* with you.”

“He belongs to my friend, and he’s important to her,” Adora said, scowling.

“I wouldn’t be able to leave a pet behind either,” the boy said. “Can you imagine? Abandoning a poor, defenseless thing…”

“He didn’t seem very defenseless when he was trying to chew your hand off.” The girl scoffed. “We’ve got half a tank of gas left. How long do you think we can go on that?”

The abrupt change of topic surprised Adora. “Awhile, it gets pretty good mileage… why?”

“Because I don’t want to go straight back to the house and lead an invasion there. We also need to go back and get the truck, though.”

“The truck can wait. I say we bring the car back and drop… sorry, what’s your name?” the boy asked, remembering they hadn’t introduced themselves. “I’m Bow, that’s Glimmer.”

“Adora.”

“And drop Adora off so your dad can look at her head. What was that flashlight made of?”

Adora rubbed her injured temple, grimacing. “Metal. Dad used to joke that it’d be a good weapon.”

"He wasn't wrong, you went *down* when she hit you with it."

Adora scooted away from Bow a bit, releasing Melog from his carrier. He immediately jumped into her lap and let her curl up, hugging him tight.

"Okay," the girl — Glimmer — said after a moment. "Let's get back to the house. It's a three-hour drive, if anything's tailing us, we'll notice."

"Their ships are visible in the sky," Bow explained. "Barely, but once you know what you're looking for, you can't miss them."

"What about Catra?"

Bow looked at Glimmer, who was practically glaring at the road. "We don't… know much about what they do to people. The only solid thing we've got is that he puts some kind of mind-control chip on their necks — that's why we had to check you. Has anything weird happened to you or… Catra in the last couple of weeks? Besides the obvious."

Adora brushed her fingers through Melog's fur, biting back tears. "Yeah. Something broke into her house one night — we live across the street from each other and we were worried about going outside, so we were just staying in and on Skype together. There were… green lights flashing in her house when I woke up. She was so freaked out when I got there."

"That's probably when they got her. Has she been acting different?"

"I mean, she's been a little quieter than usual. But she shuts down when she's stressed. How do we save her?"

Bow was pointedly not looking at Adora now. "We… don't know if that's even possible. This is so far beyond *anyone's* expertise. We're just trying to live right now."

Weren’t they all? Adora looked out the window, tears filling her eyes.

Glimmer sighed, expression softening slightly. “I’m sorry we dragged you out here. But we… want to help people however we can. And there’s strength in numbers, right?”

“If we hadn’t come here, they probably would’ve come for me eventually,” Adora muttered. “Right? Like they weren’t going to just leave me free.”

“Probably not, no,” Glimmer admitted.

“So this was for the best.”

Melog purred, nuzzling her cheek. She blew out a long breath, closing her eyes. Catra was gone the moment… *they* got into her house. Adora couldn’t have saved her.

If she told herself that enough, she might believe it.

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

Adora adjusts to her new life.

Chapter Notes

New chapter count! It might change again, who knows. I'm winging this

Day Twenty-Nine

Adora fell asleep after a bit of silence, only waking up again when Bow gently shook her shoulder. "Think you're okay to walk? It's a bit of a hike."

"What about…" Adora looked at all the supplies they had packed.

"We'll come back in a bit for everything if you decide you want to stay with us," Bow assured her. "But if you want to leave, we're not gonna take your stuff."

That was oddly kind of them. Adora nodded silently, loading Melog back into his crate and zipping it shut. She wasn't leaving *him* behind, even for a little while.

They were parked in a small carport with two other vehicles, right on the edge of a forest. Glimmer and Bow both looked out at the sky to make sure it was clear before they gestured for Adora to follow them. This felt a little too much like the beginning of a horror movie, but that was pretty much her entire life now. She followed.

"Where are we going?"

"My family's vacation home," Glimmer said. "We happened to be here when everything started, and I guess it's far enough out of the way that it hasn't been found yet. I always thought my

grandfather was crazy for building it out in the middle of nowhere, but maybe he could see the future."

The trees quickly obscured the black sky, and Adora felt a little better under the cover. Glimmer and Bow had said there was nothing watching them, and she believed them, but she was still paranoid.

They walked about four miles before Glimmer held out an arm to stop them. There was… something up ahead. Something not human, which immediately set Adora on edge, until she looked a little closer. It was about half her size, with a glowing pink panel on the front and four spidery legs. Adora narrowed her eyes a bit.

"Wait, is that… Emily?"

"Darla, actually!" Another flashlight turned on from behind a tree, and a short girl with *long* magenta hair tied up in pigtails stepped out, grinning. "Emily's back at the house, poor girl needs some repairs. Hi Adora! Where's Catra?"

"You guys know each other?" Bow asked, looking between them.

"Of course! We grew up together. I told you I had friends back home, didn't I? Adora helped me with the Emily and Darla prototypes."

Helped was a bit generous. She had mostly chased them down when they had inevitably gone rogue and attempted to invade the neighbor's house.

"*You guys* know each other?" Adora asked, raising an eyebrow.

"There's a week-long robotics seminar in Bright Moon every summer," Bow explained. "We've been going since we were thirteen."

Oh, right. Entrapta *had* mentioned that a couple times, along with meeting another person there that could almost keep up with her. "Why'd you ask about Catra?" Glimmer asked suspiciously.

"Because she's always with Adora. Given all the evidence from my observations, they really should have started dating two or three years ago, but Scorpia told me not to tell them that."

Adora blushed, ducking her head. "She's… not here. They got her."

Entrapta's expression fell for a split second before snapping back to normal. "Oh. That's… unfortunate." She turned back to look at Darla, kneeling and popping a panel open.

"What are you doing out here?" Bow asked, carefully changing the subject.

"I'm still trying to work on teaching them to scan people for any sign of foreign technology, but it's hard when I don't know exactly what to look for."

"Is the camera not working?"

"It is, but it would be a lot easier if someone didn't have to watch that twetny-four/seven."

"We have to come back this way later, we'll stop to work on it then. But you shouldn't be out here alone."

"Okay." Entrapta closed the panel, patting Darla's shell and standing. She was definitely more subdued now.

"We were trying to reach you," Adora said quietly as they continued walking. "Your phone's been going straight to voicemail."

"I smashed it," Entrapta said, shrugging. "You can never be too careful when things like this happen." As if they happened every other day. "Technology can be easily compromised, you shouldn't trust anything you didn't build yourself."

"Everything seems fine so far."

"Well, yes, clearly control through technology wasn't the goal, but I didn't know that when this started."

They walked another two miles, and Adora was starting to get a little winded when the house finally came into view. A set of stairs built into a small incline led up to a wooden, wraparound porch with a couple windows on each side of the double glass doors. It was completely dark, of course, but also seemed… welcoming.

"Grandma and Grandpa had really high hopes for lots of grandchildren," Glimmer said as she led them up the stairs. "But Aunt Casta decided she didn't want kids, and my parents stopped after me, so we just have a bunch of space. There's like… eight bedrooms upstairs and two downstairs, and a bunch of bathrooms."

"The tree cover makes it an ideal place to hide from overhead threats," Entrapta added, waving a hand at the canopy of leaves above them. "Your grandfather really thought ahead."

"Sometimes I wonder…"

"*Halt*!"

The yell nearly sent Adora tumbling back down the stairs. Bow caught her to keep her steady, while Glimmer sighed.

"*Frosta*. This is *not* the time for that."

A small shadow holding what was very obviously a dagger appeared from around a corner. "Show me your necks first."

"Seriously?"

"Now!"

"Just turn around, it's quicker," Bow said, doing as he was told. The rest followed suit. Frosta nodded after a minute, satisfied.

"Okay. You can go."

“What are you *doing* out here?” Gllimmer demanded as she climbed the steps and grabbed the dagger from the short figure.

“Standing guard! Someone has to do it.”

“Not *you*. Go inside.”

The girl grumbled as she whirled on her heel and stormed toward the doors. “Cousin on my mom’s side,” Glimmer explained tiredly. “Come on.”

The house was completely open inside, with a large fireplace immediately to the right, a couple couches gathered around. There was a full kitchen in the corner across the floor, with counters lining the wall and an island in the middle. About ten feet from where Adora stood was a winding staircase up into a loft.

“Are Mom and Dad sleeping?”

“We *were*,” a dry, melodic voice said. Adora saw a large figure at the top of the stairs. “How did it go?”

“Not… great,” Glimmer admitted, shining her flashlight up the stairs to illuminate her mother. “Can you get Dad? Someone’s hurt — not bad, don’t worry.”

Frosta went to flop on one of the couches while Entrapta made her way toward the back. A lantern clicked on, illuminating a corner full of electronic bits and pieces.

Glimmer’s father — Micah — set to work with looking at Adora’s head while Glimmer and Bow took turns explaining the situation. Adora did her best to ignore the sympathetic looks she got from the older couple.

“You’re welcome to stay,” Angella said. “There’s plenty of room, and it’s safer than being alone.”

“Only if the cat can stay too.” Adora didn’t usually make demands like that, but it wasn’t for her. It was for Catra. She’d be

devastated if anything happened to Melog.

“Of course. Although I’m not sure if we can really stop him from getting lost…”

“He’s clingy, he’ll stay with me. Or Entrapta, since he knows her too.”

Melog was still in his crate, snoozing. Frosta got down on the floor to look in at him. “Your head seems all right,” Micah reported as he bandaged the wound. “Take some aspirin for any headaches and let me know if you feel nauseous or dizzy.”

“We can get the stuff from your car, if you want,” Bow added. “You should probably rest in a bed.”

“Sure.” Adora’s voice was flat. Things were finally starting to hit her. Catra was gone. She was alone with these strangers. The world was ending.

And there was nothing she could do about it.

Day Thirty-Two

“There are no fish, either?”

“Not as far as we can tell.”

Adora was lying on her belly on the dock in the backyard, looking curiously at the water. Micah had dragged her out for some fresh air, and the lake was pretty. What she could see of it, anyway.

“And no wildlife at all.”

Micah shook his head. “The first thing Entrapta did when she and Bow got here was set up a bunch of cameras. We’ve never even seen a squirrel on them. And that’s not normal for this area at all.”

Adora reached a hand out to the water, skimming her fingers along the surface. “It’s like the entire world just stopped,” she said

quietly. Micah didn't answer.

They went back inside eventually. Adora had explained the paranoia around being outside, and everyone had admitted to feeling the same way. But it was a *little* safer out here, at least. Safe enough. Adora was still happy to get back inside, though. She made her way to Entrapta's science corner, where the girl in question was working, and where Melog was curled up in a blanket nest. He'd cried the entire first night when he realized Catra wasn't there, and now mostly spent his time with Adora or Entrapta.

Entrapta was tapping away on her laptop, frowning and biting her lip. "What's up?" Adora asked, sliding down the wall to sit with her.

"I've been thinking… it's odd that we still have power at this point. Even the best power grid should have already shut down if no one was there to maintain it. I rebuilt the wifi network when I got here in anticipation of that going down, but I thought we'd need a generator or something by now. Was there still electricity back home?"

Adora nodded. "It was still up the day we left, in my house at least."

"And that's strange. But I had an idea, so I hacked into the nearest power plant—"

"You did *what*?"

"And I think maybe the greens are maintaining it themselves so we can *keep* electricity. Look at this." Entrapta turned her laptop for Adora to see the screen. It was a map of nearby Bright Moon, painted in various colors. "It's a map of electricity usage across the city. The bright red areas are where the most electricity is being used, the gray and black where the least are." She scrolled out a little and moved her mouse around a mostly black area.

“This is where we are. Our usage is almost negligible, and once I finish the generator, we’ll be completely off the map.”

“But the city…”

“It’s only a theory,” Entrapta said quickly. “But I suspect the place with the most usage is also where the majority of chipped people are being kept. It would make sense — they still need to be able to see, and they work for the enemy now, so they have no reason to be afraid of turning on the lights. Other areas with rates of usage are probably people who reacted to this by turning on every light in their house, but they’re really just making it easier to get caught. They might as well paint a giant glowing target on their houses.”

Adora stared at the screen, feeling sick. People were trying to be safe, but they were just signing their own death sentences. “Is there any way to stop them? You’re in the system, could you shut it down?”

“Probably. But they’d be able to bring it back up. And there are people who *need* electricity. If, say, someone is on home oxygen and we cut them off…”

“We’d probably kill them,” Adora finished, shoulders falling. “You’re right. That’s bad.”

They fell silent, Adora staring at the floor while Entrapta continued exploring the power plant’s network, trying to find *anything* she could use.

The silence was broken by Bow yelling in relief. “Ha! Glimmer, I found Perfuma!”

“You did?” Glimmer called back, rushing to the stairs. Bow was already hopping down them two at a time, phone in hand.

“Yeah, she and her girlfriend had to ditch the house after their street was raided. They’re about an hour outside of Bright Moon. Car ran out of gas.”

“Wasn’t Perfuma the name of Scorpia’s girlfriend?” Entrapta asked distantly, still looking at her screen. Adora perked up slightly.

“Was it?”

“Her girlfriend’s name is Scorpia,” Bow spoke up. Adora couldn’t stop herself from feeling a flash of hope.

“Are you going to get them?”

“We need to make sure it isn’t a trap,” Glimmer said. Bow nodded.

“We’ll go, I’ll talk to them while you stay in the car. If things get bad, get out.”

“Wait, what? I’m not—“

“I’ll go too,” Adora said. “Strength in numbers, right? Two people go to talk to them while one stays in the car, ready to go if the other two have to run back.”

Glimmer looked a little more accepting of that. “Okay,” she said slowly, looking at Bow. “Let them know we’re on our way.”

“Oh, I made some communication stuff,” Entrapta said, setting her laptop aside and going to retrieve a box from one of her shelves. “It’s safer than using cellphones, and they have a range of five miles as long as the main receiver is within range as well.”

“Amazing,” Bow said, grinning. “Let’s get going.”

He grabbed his bow and arrows, and Adora grabbed Catra’s baseball bat. She gripped it tight as they marched out of the house.

Glimmer drove while Bow sorted out the communication stuff. “This is the main receiver, I assume,” he said, holding up a small box. “You don’t have to do anything once it’s turned on, just make sure it doesn’t get turned off again. Adora and I will go meet

Scorpia and Perfuma, and once we know what's going on, we'll get back to you."

"I don't like this," Glimmer said uncertainly.

"It's not great," Bow admitted. "But it's a chance to help more people."

"Yeah." Glimmer nodded. "I know."

Adora stared out the window, watching the darkness. Bow had tried to teach her about spotting the ships, but they hadn't actually seen any ships. That was for the best, but it meant Adora still didn't know what to look for.

They pulled up along the road a street over from where Perfuma said they were. "We'll check in before we make contact," Bow said as he and Adora climbed out of the car. Glimmer drummed her fingers against the steering wheel. She didn't like playing the getaway driver, but her mother wouldn't let her have a gun. "If you don't hear from us within two minutes after that, take off."

"Just be safe, okay?"

It was easy to walk unseen, though maybe not entirely unheard, considering Adora kept tripping. She missed being able to see her feet. "You all right?" Bow asked as they slowly approached a small spot of light — Perfuma's car. Adora could just make out two people sitting in it.

"Yup. Let's go."

Bow tapped the earbud in his ear. "Glimmer? We see them. Start the timer."

"*Got it*."

He pulled out his phone to send a message to Perfuma, then knocked an arrow in place. "Scorpia's pretty big, right? Think she's gonna try and attack?"

“She can’t even kill a spider. I’m not too worried about—“

“Stay back!”

They both yelped as something whistled by their heads. It was a ball, Adora realized, right as another one flew at her. She ducked; a third one hit her knee.

“Turn around!” an unfamiliar voice demanded. “Show us your necks!”

“*Perfuma*!” Bow squeaked, cowering on the ground. Adora’s fingers tightened around her bat — *wait*. She had a bat!

It was absolutely impossible to see, but she straightened up and took her best guess, swinging the bat as hard as she could. There was a sharp *crack* as the ball and bat collided, and then the sound of cracking glass as it hit a windshield.

“Woo!” Adora cheered, pumping her arms. “Fright City Little Monsters league champions three years in a row!”

“Adora?”

Oh. Right. “Scorpia!” She hurried forward, practically throwing herself into Scorpia’s waiting arms. Bow jogged up behind her, a bit winded, and smiled at Perfuma. She had the good decency to look a little sheepish.

“Sorry.”

“It’s okay. You were being careful. But for the record.” Bow did turn to expose the back of his neck. Perfuma threw her arms around him, hugging him tight. He pulled away enough to check in with Glimmer. “All good.”

“*Really*?” Glimmer sounded rightfully doubtful. “*Because I definitely just heard you screaming*.”

“They came armed. We cleared it up.”

“How are you *here*?” Scorpia asked, finally setting Adora down. Her eyes flicked to the bat. “Where’s Catra?”

And all joy was immediately zapped out of her. Her shoulders dropped, her eyes falling to the ground. “Oh.” Scorpia’s voice was quiet as she put the pieces together.

“Yeah. I’ll… explain later. Let’s just get back to the car.”

Glimmer pulled around to let Scorpia and Perfuma unload their supplies into the trunk, and they piled back into the car. Scorpia got the front seat while Bow, Adora, and Perfuma squeezed into the back.

“I *knew* that Twitter was you,” Perfuma said with a note of pride in her voice when Glimmer explained the Rebellion Twitter. “It sounds like you’ve learned a lot about them.”

“We’ve had a lot of help. A friend of Bow’s came with him from the robot symposium—“

“Entrapta!” Adora said before she could forget.

“Really?” Scorpia sounded absolutely delighted. “That’s great! I was really worried about you guys. I talked to Catra on Facebook for a bit, but she stopped responding. I kinda thought that was just her being her — you know she is about keeping up conversations — and I was going to message her again right before those… things… came after us—“

“It was already too late.” Adora’s voice was bitter.

“Is… Is there a way to get her back?”

“We don’t know,” Glimmer said slowly. “We haven’t really had a chance to experiment with things like that.”

“Right.” Scorpia’s shoulders fell. Perfuma leaned forward to rest her hand on her shoulder. “Yeah. But I’m sure it’ll be fine.”

She was always an optimist. Adora had to admire that. Especially since she wasn't feeling overly optimistic herself at the moment.

Day Thirty-Seven

Melog was thrilled to have another person he recognized around, and spent a lot more time following Scorpia or riding around on her shoulder. He always came back to sleep with Adora, though.

Glimmer, meanwhile, was energized. "There are more people out there. There *have* to be. What if we could reach them? We could fight back!"

"I'm starting to think that Twitter account was a bad idea," Angella said slowly. She was on her own phone, scrolling through it. "I don't want you getting into trouble, Glimmer."

"But what if we can fight them?" Glimmer countered. "Maybe we don't have to just roll over and die or struggle to live. We might not be able to bring the sun back, but we can live in peace!"

Adora was curled up on the couch opposite Angella and Micah, watching Glimmer pace. Bow was sitting beside Adora, working on his bow.

"I've been thinking," Micah said slowly. "We should try and hit up a pharmacy."

"Why? They've probably all been looted by now."

"For first-aid materials and things like painkillers, yes. But no one in apocalypse movies ever considers the importance of vitamins."

"Vitamins?" Glimmer repeated, frowning.

"Yes. Do you think living without a sun is healthy for us?"

"And it might be worth looking around Bright Moon a little," Bow added. "Entrapta's got that electricity use map, so we know where to avoid. We can map out safe places and hit those."

Angella didn't look overly thrilled by the idea. "We can't just stay here forever, Mom," Glimmer said. "We have to do *something*, even if it's just for us. And we'll be careful. We got Perfuma and Scorpia without any problems."

"Tell that to the bruise on my knee," Adora grumbled. Glimmer waved her off.

"It's fine, right? You can move?"

"Yeah, I've worked through worse."

"We'll be careful," Micah assured his wife. "But I think this is something we need to do."

Angella sighed, but nodded. "All right. Take tonight to get ready. You can go tomorrow."

Night and *day* were a bit relative, considering it was currently three p.m., and most of them would be going to bed soon. They'd adjusted to a weird nocturnal/diurnal hybrid schedule. Not that any of it mattered without sunlight. Maybe the people the greens had captured had a more consistent schedule. It'd be useful to know for getting around them.

Scorpia was lying on her stomach in bed when Adora walked by the room, playing with Melog. There were eight bedrooms, each pair of two sharing a bathroom, and a master suite downstairs with its own bathroom, and another bedroom off Entrapta's nook. Adora could hear the shower she shared with Perfuma and Scorpia running. She flopped into bed, staring at the baseball bat in the corner.

Was Catra in Bright Moon now? Or Plumeria? Or across the world? Anything was possible. She could be *in space*. Completely out of reach. Adora might never see her again.

The thought made her heart ache. She rolled onto her other side, away from the bat, and closed her eyes, ready for another night of broken sleep.

Day Thirty-Eight

The closest pharmacy was right on the edge of Bright Moon, in one of the darker areas. They parked in front to have a quick get away, and Micah led the way to clear it out. The pharmacy had be thoroughly ransacked, leaving litter across the floor, but the vitamin aisle was largely untouched. A few bottles had been knocked off the shelves, breaking and scattering pills that crunched underfoot.

"Excellent," Micah said, sweeping every bottle into the bag he'd brought. Adora wandered over to the next aisle, bat hanging loosely at her side as she walked. There was a lone first-aid kit, which she grabbed, and some packs of band-aids that had been left behind. They also went into the bag. Bow and Glimmer climbed over the pharmacy counter to see if anything in the back had been missed.

The next aisle was office supplies. Adora wasn't sure what possessed her to grab several notebooks and packs of pens, but they'd probably be useful in the apocalypse, right?

She came to a stop at a pile of sketchbooks, ignoring the lump that threatened to rise in her throat. They were shitty, cheap ones that Catra bought and hid under her floorboards from her mother, along with her impressive collection of markers and colored pencils. She'd learned early in life not to let her mother see things that brought her joy.

Adora grabbed the entire pile, dropping it in her bag, along with ten packs of colored pencils. Catra would need something to draw with when she came back.

There was a *click* behind her, and something cold pressed against the back of her head. "Don't move," a low voice warned. Adora nearly dropped her bag. "Everyone stop, or I shoot the girl," the voice called, louder. All activity around the pharmacy immediately ceased. Adora held her breath, eyes closed, as the person with the gun to her head grabbed her ponytail, lifting it to carefully

check her neck. Then the hand pushed her shoulder to move her forward. "All of you where I can see you, hands up, now."

Glimmer and Bow very slowly climbed back out into the main store, and Micah turned a corner, both hands up, one still gripping the bag. "Turn around. Let me see your necks."

The gun *finally* left Adora's head when the woman saw the unmarred necks of the others. "All right. Now what the hell are you doing in my home?"

Adora stumbled toward Micah, turning to look at the woman. She was black, with a cloud of white hair and hard dark eyes. "Uh… robbing it?" Bow said, rubbing the back of his head. "Why do you live here?"

"Because I need to stay close to those alien bastards if I want to figure out a way to get my wife back."

Oh. Adora looked at the sketchbooks in her bag. "They got your wife?" Micah asked quietly. The woman nodded once.

"We had an elderly neighbor she tried to take care of. She was over there one day when they hit our street, and…" The woman paused, then shook her head. "I barely got away. Followed them to Bright Moon. And I've been watching ever since."

"You *have*?" Glimmer's tone had barely concealed excitement ringing in it. "You must know so much about them."

"A bit," the woman said slowly. "Sorry, who're you guys?"

"I'm Micah," the man quickly introduced himself. "This is my daughter, Glimmer, and her friends, Bow and Adora."

The woman looked between them, and nodded. "Netossa," she said finally. "I'd say good to meet you, but I could do without the circumstances."

"Can't say we disagree," Micah said.

“So if you’re trying to save your wife,” Glimmer jumped in. “Do you know how to get the chips off?”

“Not… really,” Netossa said, grimacing. “I’ve been taking this one step at a time.”

“You should come with us! We have a place not far out of Bright Moon, we’ve been trying to figure out ways to fight them. I bet you could help. And we can help find a way to save your wife!”

“Glimmer,” Micah scolded her gently. Netossa tilted her head, looking a little bewildered.

“Fight them? Really? They’re an intergalactic army with some… really weird shit going on from what I can tell. You’re four people with a baseball bat, a bow, and a gun.”

“There’s more of us. And if you join, there’ll be even more. If there’s any way for us to even get a chance, then shouldn’t we work together?”

Netossa looked around the darkened store, then back at the group. “I dunno. I’ve got a decent set up here, and I want to stay close to Spinny.”

“A friend of ours is working on setting up communication outside of using cellphones,” Bow said helpfully. “As long as she hasn’t blown herself up with the ham radio since we left. What if we just stay in contact? We can share information, and if you need help, you can call us.”

“That… might work,” Netossa agreed, nodding once. “Are phones still working?”

“Yeah, but Entrapta thinks it’s better for us to get off an easily traceable line of communication.”

“And she’s seen every sci-fi and apocalypse movie ever made in four languages,” Adora added. “So she probably knows best.”

"I'll take your word on that one. But okay. Take my phone number for now, and let me know when you've got something else. You know where I live, obviously."

Glimmer was nearly vibrating as they got back in the car. "We recruited someone!" she said excitedly.

"Glimmer, this isn't a game," Micah reminded her.

"And I'm not playing. I really want to fight."

"I know you do. But if you really want to do this, then you have to take it seriously."

"I *am*."

Adora curled up in her seat, head resting on the window, and sighed.

Day Forty-Two

"Can you still hear me?"

There was a crackle of static before Bow answered. "*Yes!*"

Entrapta squealed, clapping her hands together. "That's twenty miles! A little bit more and we should be able to get in touch with your friend in Bright Moon."

"This is *great*," Glimmer said emphatically. "You're amazing, Entrapta."

A thud from the other room cut her off. "Adora! Stop hitting tennis balls in the house!"

Adora studiously ignored her, throwing another ball up in the air and swinging. She couldn't practice outside, because she'd end up losing balls, but she needed to stay sharp, and it had been forever since she'd played softball.

“Maybe you should take it ouside,” Micah suggested from the stairs. He mostly sounded amused.

“Don’t want to lose the balls.”

“I can find other things to throw at you.”

Adora paused, looking at him, then nodded. They dug up a box of old junk and went outside. “I always hoped Glimmer would be more into sports,” Micah said conversationally as he pulled an old cellphone out of the box and tossed it. It was satisfying to hear it shatter when the bat hit it. “She was more into politics, though. Youngest student council president in twenty years. Her opponents were convinced she cheated somehow.”

An old rubber dog bone was next. “I’d vote for her,” Adora said, grunting as she hit the bone.

“She’s a natural leader. Just has to learn to hone it a bit better.” An old stuffed animal was next. It was light, and Adora wasn’t quite sure if she hit it, but it went flying.

“This is more Catra’s thing than mine. I was the school quarterback.”

“Run head first into a problem?” Micah guessed, producing a baseball from the box next. The air cracked as the bat connected with it, the force shaking her hands.

“It’s what I’m best at.”

“I dunno, you seem pretty good at this, too.” A paperweight was next. It didn’t go far, and it almost hurt to hit, but Adora managed.

“I played softball in middle school. Catra was better, though.”

“I’m sure her parents were proud.”

Adora laughed so hard she completely missed whatever Micah threw at her. It was a completely humorless sound. "Her dad took off before she was born, and her mother was a terrible person. Maybe still is, who knows. She wasn't home when the sun disappeared, and I don't think Catra even tried to get in contact with her."

"Ah." Micah sighed, shoulders dropping. "I've never understood people who can be cruel to their own kids. I saw so many abused kids in the ER… almost punched a guy once."

"I pushed her once." Adora almost smiled. "Catra missed curfew, and she grabbed her right in the front lawn, and… I don't know what happened, I just got mad. I'm sure she got in trouble for it, but she never told me. She just kept talking about how cool it was to see her mother go down like that."

Looking back, Adora was fairly sure that was when she'd fallen in love with Catra. They were only twelve, and most people would scoff at the thought. But she knew. She had seen the way Ms. Weaver had grabbed her, and she had seen red. She had crossed the yards without thinking, and the next thing she remembered was holding Catra in her arms.

That had been it. *Catra* had been it for Adora. She knew it then, and she knew it now.

What she didn't know was what she would do if Catra never came home.

Day Forty-Two

"There! See the shadow?"

Adora squinted against the black sky. "Yeah… sort of. It kind of looks like a triangle?"

"Yeah, that's it."

Bow, realizing Adora was getting antsy, had taken her and driven nearly two hours from the house, and they'd hid in a parking garage, watching the sky. He was right — they were easy to spot once Adora really *looked*. It was like there was a hole in the darkness that was somehow *more* black.

"It's too bad whatever they did took the stars too," he said thoughtfully, resting his elbows on his knees. "Imagine what the sky would look like without any light pollution."

"Catra said the same thing," Adora said, keeping her eyes on the sky. "We used to camp in my backyard, and talked my parents into turning off all the lights, but it never really did any good."

"I used to go camping with my brothers," Bow said. "Sometimes just a couple of them, but sometimes *all* of them. Our dads thought we were crazy, but they were never outdoor people."

It was the first time he had mentioned any family, Adora realized. She took a chance and pressed. "How many brothers do you have?"

"Twelve." Adora nearly choked on her own breath. Bow laughed. "My dads wanted a big family."

"Have you… been in touch with them?"

"Sorta." Bow sighed. "They're both terrible with their phones, but they've been answering when I text. Most of my brothers were out of touch already when everything happened — in different countries, no cell signal, all that. They're smart, though. They'll be okay."

Adora leaned over to rest her head on Bow's shoulder. He wrapped an arm around her shoulders, pulling her close. "What about you? You mentioned parents…"

"They were on vacation. I haven't heard from them since the first day. Their phones went straight to voicemail on the second day."

Adora closed her eyes, swallowing hard. "I've been trying not to think too much about it."

"Yeah. I get that."

They sat in silence, under cover, until the ship passed them by, and it was safe to leave.

Day Forty-Six

"I wonder how the chips work," Entrapta said thoughtfully, looking up from her laptop. "The back of the neck is a very specific place."

"You think there's a reason for it?" Bow asked. Adora sat up on the couch to look toward Entrapta's alcove-lab.

"I have no idea. But there has to be, right? I wonder if it taps into people's nervous systems…"

Melog jumped up onto the couch, nuzzling Adora's arm and meowing. It was time for food. Adora ignored him.

"I guess that'd make sense. But that means it'd be dangerous to try and take them off."

"It'd probably be disastrous. We could accidentally paralyze or kill someone."

That was a truth Adora refused to acknowledge. That Catra might be gone forever. That there was never a chance to save her. That she'd been gone the moment they'd put the chip on her.

She lied down again, squeezing her eyes shut and pushing back tears. She couldn't think about it. She wouldn't think about it. They *would* save Catra. They'd find a way.

They *had* to find a way.

The Chips

Chapter Summary

The Rebellion finally gets a small win

Chapter Notes

This was going to be three chapters, I SWEAR, but if I kept it to three, y'all just would've been waiting longer for an update, and I felt bad about that. So we're going to four chapters *sigh*

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day Ninety-Six

"*Nothing new to report. It seems like they've slowed down a bit.*" Netossa crossed her arms, frowning. "*I* know *there are still other people around. I found some new people the other day when one of them lit something on fire…*"

"Any luck with finding Spinnerella?" Glimmer asked. Netossa's expression softened, and she sighed.

"*No. I'm starting to think she might not be in Bright Moon anymore. If she's even…*" Netossa's voice drifted off. "*I mean… there's no way he's keeping them* all *alive, right? There are people who just… wouldn't be useful in an alien invasion.*"

Adora gripped Catra's bat tighter and swung it again.

She'd realized early on that she couldn't sit in on Netossa's reports from Bright Moon. They just upset her. Everyone understood, but it wasn't like she could really escape them unless she wanted to leave the house all together; she could at least pretend she wasn't listening by disappearing into the makeshift gym they'd turned one of the rooms into and working out. Micah had helped her set up a couple makeshift heavy bags that she usually beat on the

bat. It helped with her upper-body strength and some of her nervous energy.

Glimmer, Bow, and Micah were across the hall, talking to Netossa on the souped up tablets Entrapta had made for easier communication. Video allowed them to check each other's necks and make sure no one had been compromised. It turned out electronics stores were another largely untapped resource in the apocalypse; they'd spent an entire day loading two cars with enough stuff to easily fill Entrapta's little lab, with overflow.

"Adora!"

Speak of the devil. She was lucky Adora didn't accidentally turn around and hit her. "Entrapta! Jeez. Hi. What's up?"

"Would you be interested in some minor kidnapping?"

"Uh…"

"I've been working on different ways to deal with the chips, and I think the easiest way short term would be to find a way to short circuit the chip so it goes offline. From there we take the person to a secure location and keep them unconscious while we work on a way to safely remove the chip. It may require raiding a hospital — Micah will probably be able to help with that."

"Okay, okay," Adora said quickly. "Slow down. That requires a lot of leg work. We'd have to focus on one place to target, and find a safe place to set up, and—"

"And you've been itching to get out of here, haven't you? I think a little scouting mission would be good for you!"

"I… I think we need to talk to the others about this," Adora said slowly. "We can't make decisions on our own."

"Oh, good point." Entrapta raised her voice to yell, "I need to talk to everyone!"

There was no way for anyone to pretend they hadn't heard that.

Everyone gathered in the living room, listening intently as Entrapta explained her plan practically in one breath.

"I like it," Glimmer said immediately. "Let's go."

"Not so fast," Angella said sternly. "There's a *lot* of planning that has to be done before even considering something this dangerous."

"So, let's plan! What do we need?"

"We'll need a separate place to work, to start," Bow said slowly. "We can't bring someone back here unless we're absolutely certain it's going to work."

"I'm sure we can find a store or something," Entrapta spoke up. "Like your Bright Moon friend. And I can set up security on the parameters."

"Then we just need to grab a person, right?" Glimmer asked.

"And try to pry a chip out of their neck that may or may not be attached to their nervous system," Micah reminded her. "Without killing them."

"We have to *try*. It's the only way we're ever going to accomplish anything."

Day One-Hundred Ten

They'd set up shop in an old electronics repair shop. The place hadn't been picked clean, which meant Entrapta got even more to work with, and it was small enough that Glimmer, Bow, and Adora could easily guard it.

Getting someone alone was a little harder. They were right on the edge of Elberon, which seemed to be a hub for the chipped people, but they were always *together*. Entrapta's suggestion for

disabling the chip was basically a small EMP bomb, so they were really depending on alien technology to work the same way as Earth electronics. It was all a stretch.

Adora was outside the store, crouched and balancing on the balls of her feet. Glimmer and Bow were on either side, staring at the ground. Entrapta and Micah were in the store. They hadn't spoken in nearly an hour.

"The EMP bomb worked," Glimmer said quietly. Adora didn't say anything. "It's a step, right? We know how to—"

"How to what? Catch them and kill them? Great."

The bitterness in Adora's voice was obvious. Glimmer winced. "We just… have to keep trying—"

"How many people do you want to experiment on before we just admit we can't do anything about it?" Adora pushed herself up, storming off aimlessly. Micah had declared the person — *their victim* — dead after half an hour, but Entrapta had insisted on getting the chip out anyway, to study it. What she planned to do with it, Adora had no idea. She didn't want to think too hard about it.

She wandered aimlessly down the street, bat hanging loosely at her side. This street was deserted — they'd staked it out for an entire week before determining that it didn't get much use and would be a perfect place to set up their temporary base.

They'd known there was a risk. It was why Micah had sent them outside under the guise of guard duty. Entrapta had insisted on staying, though. Adora wondered if she was okay. She *acted* okay, which was maybe the most worrying thing. She acted like she had already adjusted, like this was the *new normal*. It had only been a few months… hadn't it? Time was hard to measure without the sun. But it hadn't been long enough for Entrapta to become well adjusted to it all. Even Glimmer, who had barely waited a month

before organizing a rebellion, still expressed remorse and sadness about all of this.

Adora stopped walking, staring at her reflection in a shop window. *She* still felt things, but sometimes it felt like she'd forgotten how to express them. Maybe she was just projecting.

Maybe you're thinking too much, a voice that sounded suspiciously like Catra's whispered in the back of her mind. *God* she wished Catra was with her. She'd probably be better at this. She was better at everything.

"Adora?" Bow called gently. "We're leaving."

She turned back to look at him, meeting his sad gaze. "Yeah. Okay."

Day One-Hundred Nineteen

"So she's your girlfriend?"

"No," Adora said, a bit too defensively. Netossa looked up from Adora's phone, raising an eyebrow. On the screen was a picture of her and Catra, with Catra on her back, laughing. "Not… Not really. We never… I was gonna ask her to go to prom with me."

God that seemed so stupid now. She was sitting in an abandoned pharmacy with a woman who'd put a gun to her head, at the end of the world, with no sun and no *hope.* And she was talking about asking Catra to go to prom.

"She couldn't be out. Her mom, ya know."

Netossa rolled her eyes. "I can guess."

"But we had plans. We were going to go to college together, and room together until we could get our own place, and—"

"And definitely not date?"

"We didn't talk about that," Adora said, blushing. Netossa reached over to pat the top of her head.

"Did you at least get a kiss?" Adora's blush darkened. "Oooooooh, you *did*."

"It doesn't count!" Adora insisted, voice cracking. "It was spin the bottle at Scorpia's fourteenth birthday party. I *think* she kinda had a crush on Catra, but she ended up with some boy whose parents were friends with her moms, and Catra got me."

"Ah, spin the bottle." Netossa pretended to wipe a tear from her eye. "Classic."

"But she wasn't just…" Adora's voice drifted off, and she sighed. "She's been my best friend since we were four. We moved in across the street from her and her mom, and she bolted out into the street to run over and meet me. Her mother was probably really mad, because she had to come over and make nice with my parents, but she never stopped us from being friends. Sometimes Catra would come over, and I don't think she even asked her mom. I don't think her mom noticed when she was gone."

"One of those types, got it."

"She was *such* a big part of my life. I don't… think I can imagine living without her." Adora wiped her eyes, smiling weakly. "Is that stupid?"

"Nope." Netossa put a hand on her shoulder, giving her a very serious expression. "That's love."

And, well… Adora kind of knew that already, didn't she?

Day One-Hundred Thirty-Two

"How's it going with the chip?"

"Okay, I think," Entrapta said uncertainly, carefully adjusting the dials on an old radio she'd gotten… somewhere. "It's not active,

which is good because if it was, I think they'd be able to track it. *But* I think it's still giving off lowkey signals, and if I'm right…"

She paused. The radio was static for a moment before it let out a god awful screech. Several people throughout the house yelled, and Melog darted out of his nest, probably to the safety of Scorpia's arms.

"Aha!" Entrapta said happily, turning the dial again to stop the noise.

"What *was* that?" Adora demanded, cautiously lowering her hands from her ears.

"Feedback! It took a bit of fiddling, but I managed to tune the chip to a radio wave."

"Meaning…?"

"Meaning I can now pick up whatever it's broadcasting on a radio. If I can amplify it a bit, I might be able to figure out what the signal is."

"With*out* exposing our hiding place, I assume?" Angella said from the door.

"Absolutely. I *think* it has to be attached to a live person for it to connect back to the greens. Just a theory, but they haven't found us yet, and it's been twenty-two days, soooooo…"

"Wait, you're keeping track of time?"

"I have rough estimates. It's been somewhere around one-hundred and thirty days since the sun disappeared, but I can't tell you exactly what day it is." Entrapta shrugged. "Anyway, if they were going to come for us, I think they would have already. Especially since we… stole their technology."

Right. Because the aliens probably didn't care about the person they'd murdered. Just the chip attached to their neck. "I think

part of the reason we failed is that the chip was tightly bound to the person," Entrapta went on, ignoring the heaviness in the room. "*But* I've already figured out a way to disrupt the signal and knock a person out, which means I'm probably on the right track for disabling it permanently while it's still attached to a person. Then it would be like taking a tic out of someone's skin."

She was dancing around the major flaw here — that they would need to catch another person and use them as a test subject. Risk killing another person. And maybe death was better than a lifetime of servitude to the greens, but who were they to decide something like that?

"I'll keep working with what I have," Entrapta said with an amount of confidence Adora *wished* she could feel. "I'm getting somewhere. I can feel it."

Angella nodded, frowning. Adora knew she was thinking about Micah, and the toll that first… experiment had taken on him. He'd been a surgeon. He had experienced people dying under his hand more than once. But something about this time had been different. More profound.

And it wasn't like anyone of them could really *help*. Bow had gotten queasy just *talking* about dissecting a frog in Biology. Entrapta didn't deal with humans beyond how technology could help them. And they were all just… teenagers trying to live with the hand they'd been dealt. They weren't equipped for *this*. Nobody was.

Day One-Hundred Thirty-Seven

"*I found them*!"

The sound of Netossa's voice from across the hall snapped Adora out of her daze. "What?" Glimmer demanded. "Who?"

"*Spinny. And Adora's girlfriend. They're in Erelandia*."

Adora ran across the hall and burst into Glimmer's room, grabbing the tablet from her. "Are you *sure*?"

"*I'm sure about Spinny*," Netossa said, half-apologetically. She looked frazzled and exhausted. "*And like ninety percent certain about Catra. It'd help if I could see her eyes, but the rest of her looks pretty much like that picture*."

Adora's heart skipped a beat. Erelendia. That wasn't far from here. Had Catra been that close the entire time? The thought made her heart ache.

"We still don't know how to get the chips off," Bow pointed out, bringing Adora's heart plummeting back to Earth. Right. It wouldn't do any good if they just killed Catra.

Netossa was quiet for a moment, staring at some point off screen. "*Can you try if I bring you Spinny?*"

"What?" Glimmer's and Bow's mouths fell open. "You can't be serious—"

"*I don't particularly love the idea of letting someone experiment on my wife, no. But… But I know her. She wouldn't want to be used like this. And I can't just… leave her*."

Pain seemed to choke Netossa. She kept her eyes firmly on whatever spot she was staring at off-screen. "We need to talk to my dad," Glimmer said finally. "You've got a place nearby, I'm guessing?"

"*Yeah*."

"Okay. We'll get back to you."

Glimmer took the tablet and ended the call, sighing heavily. "We can't really… do that to her wife, can we?" Bow asked quietly.

"The last person was someone's husband, I'm sure. Or son, or brother, or friend…" Glimmer curled in on herself. "Everyone is

someone. We can't get their consent, but if Netossa really wants us to…"

She pushed herself up, heading for the door. "I'm going to ask Mom and Dad what they think."

Bow looked at Adora. "What do *you* think?"

"I'm not sure," Adora admitted quietly. "I mean, I know if it was me, I'd rather die than be controlled."

"Do you think Catra would feel the same way?"

Adora opened and closed her mouth few times, trying to figure out an answer. Catra had always complained about being stuck under her mother's controlling thumb. Being *literally* controlled by someone was probably her worst nightmare.

"Yeah," she said finally. "I think she would."

And if she had to make that choice for Catra… then she would have to live with it.

Day One-Hundred Fifty

"You guys are sure you want to do this, right?" Netossa asked, looking between the group. Entrapta was sitting on the floor of the small bookstore, fiddling with the radio she had brought.

"If you're sure you want to go through with it," Micah said. Netossa hesitated, eyes dropping to the floor. "We can wait—"

"No. If you can do it, we're doing it. Even if Spinny…" She closed her eyes, shuddering. "It's better this way. She'd be happier."

Micah nodded. "All right. Let's get going, then."

Netossa could have gone alone to find Spinnerella. Entrapta equipped her with a couple of small EMP bombs, and she could take care of herself in a fight if it came to it. But Adora wanted to

go with her. Bow and Glimmer didn't need her help standing guard, and if there was a chance she could see Catra… she had to take it.

"What are they *doing*?" Adora asked as they parked the car and began the walk to town. She couldn't really figure out what the point of the small hubs of controlled people were for.

"A lot of standing around, from what I can tell," Netossa said. "There are… clones, I guess? I think? A bunch of aliens who all look the same that are running the show. They're restructuring the city for… something. No idea what. There are a lot of supply ships too. There's a small clinic they bring people to, probably for chipping, but uh… some people don't come out."

Adora decided not to ask what that meant.

Downtown Erelandia was a beacon of light in never-ending darkness. They stuck to the shadows as they approached, the light setting her on edge. Darkness had become her safe haven.

"This way," Netossa whispered, skirting the edge of the town and leading Adora around. "I've seen Spinny at the clinic mostly. She was a nurse, so I guess it just works out. I've seen Catra helping wrangle people they catch."

They finally made their way into town, still trying to keep to the shadows, but it was harder now. The light felt suffocating. Adora kept her eyes down, fingers clenched around Catra's bat. Netossa led her into an alley across the street from the clinic, eyes fixed on the door.

"I've never seen anyone leave to sleep," Netossa said. "I'm not sure if these aliens actually let them take care of themselves or how they're even still alive."

Adora shook her head. She didn't want to think about it. "So how are we doing this?"

The doors of the clinic opened, and Adora was immediately distracted by the sight of the young woman walking out. Her hair was still wild, untamed, her movements fluid and graceful in a way that was almost too good to be natural, if Adora didn't know any better. Her eyes were solid green, making her ache for the blue and yellow gaze of her best friend.

"Is that…?"

"Yeah," Adora breathed, clutching the bat tighter. Everything in her screamed to go to Catra, to beat up the clones flanking her, to drag her away from all of this. "Yeah. That's her."

Netossa looked at Adora for a long moment. "We can take her instead," she said finally. "I'll come back for Spinny later."

Catra was already disappearing down the street, looking small between her alien escorts. "No. We have a plan. We're sticking to it. We can come back for her."

Just hang on a little longer, Catra. I promise *I'll come back for you*.

"Okay." Netossa refocused on the clinic. "Be ready to swing as soon as we get in. There are probably clone guards." Clones. Good. Adora didn't have to hold back. "I'll deal with Spinny. You ready?"

"Yeah." Adora raised the bat. "Let's go."

She was running on pure adrenaline, and tunnel visioned as she kicked the clinic doors open, immediately swinging at the white-clad clones who tried to attack. She had no idea how alien anatomy worked, but most things probably couldn't survive a blow to the head. She heard a yell, then Netossa calling, "Let's go!"

Adora took a point again, hurrying out the door. There were already figures coming down the street toward them, on both sides. There were humans and clones in the groups, which meant

Adora couldn't just swing indiscriminately. Well, she wasn't Fright City High's starting quarterback for nothing.

She gripped the bat in both hands, braced herself, and rushed forward, Netossa right on her heels. Hands grabbed her and nails scratched her skin, and she definitely hit a few people with the bat, but it was better than the alternative. She had turn a few times to make sure Netossa was still with her; the woman kept up surprisingly well considering she was carrying her wife on her back.

They broke through the crowd, stumbling and hurrying down the street. "You okay?" Netossa gasped.

"Never better." She really needed to get back into a regular workout routine. More people and clones were pouring out of the buildings now, descending on them. Word had apparently gotten around fast about what was happening. "Almost… there…"

They staggered over the town line as a ship swooped in overhead. The car was waiting just ahead, and Adora thought now that it was best she had helped with this. Netossa threw the back door open, dropping into the back, and Adora dove into the driver's seat, turning the waiting key nearly hard enough to break it. The engine revved as she slammed her foot down on the gas, and they sped off. The glow of the city quickly faded in the rear-view mirror. They drove in silence for several miles before Adora finally spoke.

"Anything following us?"

She had to slow down so Netossa could stick her head out the window and examine the sky. "Nope… think we lost 'em. Fancy alien spaceships can't keep up with an old Toyota, huh?"

"Yeah." Adora blew out a long breath, head spinning. "Yeah. I guess."

They still took a long, inconsistent route back to the bookstore, just in case. Adrenaline crash hit Adora like a freight train; she

just about collapsed against Bow, who kindly saved her from dropping to the ground.

She awoke some time later to crying.

It didn't work. Adora's heart dropped to her stomach. They'd killed Netossa's wife. They were never going to figure it out. They were all doomed. They—

"Netty, sweetheart." The voice was weak and unfamiliar. "I'm really okay."

Adora ripped back her sleeping bag and stumbled up, into the front of the store, where Micah had been setting up the counter for the chip removal. Netossa was sitting on the counter, clutching her wife against her chest and clearly trying to collect herself. She wasn't doing a great job.

"I — I thought — I—"

"Thought you were getting rid of me that easily?" Spinnerella teased. Netossa laughed, pressing a kiss to her wife's forehead.

"Hey." Glimmer and Bow appeared at her side as if by magic. "Feeling better?"

She was feeling a little lightheaded, actually, but that was the least of her concerns. "Did… Did it work?"

"Yeah." Bow squeezed her shoulder, and Glimmer grinned. "Yeah, it worked."

Day One-Hundred Fifty-Three

Netossa and Spinnerella joined them at the house. There was no reason for them to stay out, exposed, in danger, and Spinnerella needed somewhere *comfortable* to relax and recover. She slept a lot for the first day or so while Netossa stood guard, as if she expected someone here to even *look* at her wrong.

She felt a bit better by the second day — enough to eat and tell them a little bit about what she had learned.

"It was like… like some kind of hive mind. All the clones and everyone who's chipped all over the world are part of it." Spinnerella rubbed the back of her neck as she spoke, fingering the bandage over the healing wound.

"Was there someone leading it?" Glimmer asked while Netossa took Spinnerella's hand, squeezing it gently.

"Yeah. His name is… Prime." Spinnerella shuddered slightly. "The clones all look like him. He… He has this massive empire all over the universe of planets he's invaded, just like he's doing to ours. He chips the entire planet, drains it of all its resources, and leaves the inhabitants to die while he moves on to the next planet."

Adora clenched her fingers into tight fists, gritting her teeth. "So there's… nothing we can do?" Bow asked, expression falling.

"I don't know. No one's ever beaten him before… clearly."

"What about the sun? And moon, and stars?"

"A shield. He's basically wrapped the planet up in a giant bubble and blocked out space so no one else could invade while he was here. But I think… I think the invasion may have started before that. There were people in the hive mind who'd been chipped for a long, long time. I could feel it. I could feel *all* of them."

"That would explain the lack of response from governments, and why all the news went dark after the first day."

Spinnerella nodded slowly. "He had plans in place to cut people off and keep them docile before he set everything in motion. He underestimated social media, though."

"And he's let us keep electricity."

"He's depending on the instinct to get away from the dark as a way to find people. Lit up houses are basically a beacon for his clones."

Glimmer was on her phone, typing furiously. "What are you doing?" Micah asked warily.

"Putting information on Twitter. Knowing more is going to keep people alive."

Adora looked at her, then at Spinnerella, swallowing a lump in her throat. "The… The girl who was in the clinic with you before we broke in — short, messy brown hair, tan skin?"

Spinnerella nodded. "She helps with subduing people who are brought in to be chipped. Surprisingly strong for how small she is."

"Her name's Catra. Do you know *anything* about her? Is she okay?"

There's an almost immediate understanding in Spinnerella's expression. "I… felt her through the hive mind a couple times. I don't know if I can say she's *okay*, but she's alive."

"And now we can save her too," Bow assured Adora. She rested a hand on his arm, trying to steady herself through the sudden dizziness. They could save Catra.

Maybe everything really would be okay.

Day One-Hundred Sixty

"They're going to be on guard. We can't just run back in right away."

"I *know*," Adora huffed, glaring out at the lake. Micah was trying to be the voice of reason as he tossed things for Adora to swing at. "But what if she gets sent somewhere else? How long do you think it'd take to find her? What if I never see her again?"

"I know you're worried," Micah said. "And we'll go back for her. Just not right now."

Adora flexed her fingers against the baseball bat, growling under her breath. She knew it was selfish to ask everyone to run into this again. But she also knew she couldn't wait.

Which left her with one absolutely terrible choice.

Day One-Hundred Sixty-Two

Don't get taken alive.

That was the only thing on Adora's mind as she tucked a pistol into her waistband and grabbed the baseball bat. She had parked in the same place she and Netossa had parked last time, because she knew how to get back there. She blew out a long breath before starting forward. She would get Catra out, or die trying. There were no other options.

She knew a little bit more, at least. She knew that the entire hive mind would be alerted as soon as she knocked Catra out, and she had to be quick. The element of surprise wasn't going to last long. She knew she had to get Catra alone.

She knew this was a terrible idea and she was probably going to die. But at least she wouldn't sell the others out.

The buildings on the town's main street were fairly close together — very few of them even had alleys between them. Which gave Adora a new idea as she approached. There was a dumpster behind one of the empty storefronts; she climbed up and reached for the edge of ceiling. The bat, in a makeshift sheath on her back, bumped against her as she pulled herself up. It wasn't perfect; she'd have to jump down and cross streets to get to the clinic, where she'd hopefully find Catra, but at least she could jump across rooftops for a bit.

"*Catra! This is* stupid*!"*

"*Aaaawww, are you scared?" Catra teased, poking Adora's cheek. Her idea of sneaking out and having a good time was apparently* parkouring *around downtown Fright City at three a.m.*

"*No, I just want to* live*."*

"*If you learn how to fall, you won't die. Besides, I've been practicing." Catra shook her limbs out, hopping on the balls of her feet. "Watch this."*

"*Don't—!"*

Too late. Catra was already running across the roof they had climbed onto, and launched herself off the edge. Adora squeaked, too horrified to make any other noises. She only let herself breathe again when Catra landed on the roof next door.

Adora had never been as good at all the jumping and moving as Catra. But she was good enough to jump roofs until she was at an intersection halfway down the street. The lack of activity in the area assured her she hadn't been seen. There was a fire escape for her to climb down, and she landed on the ground, taking off across the street and diving into the closest shadows. Drones buzzed overhead, but they went by without taking notice of her. Drones. Those were new. She'd have to let Entrapta know. If she lived.

She settled into the alley across from the clinic, tucking herself under the edge of the building roof as best she could. She had no idea, of course, what the drones could see. But if she could make it harder on them to find her, then good.

Time passed. She didn't know how much — she hadn't brought her phone, or tablet, or anything that might have helped lead the aliens back to the house. They weren't taking her alive, and she wouldn't sell the others out.

"Let me go!"

The yell broke Adora out of her trance. She looked up to see someone struggling as they were led down the street by two clones… and Catra. Right. She helped collect unchipped humans. Adora reached up to pull the baseball bat out, readying it. The boy trying to fight Catra off was probably around their age, with floppy blonde hair and wide, terrified eyes.

Adora couldn't stand there and let this happen.

She liked to think she was efficient, catching the trio right as they turned their backs to the alley. She swung the bat, managing to hit both clones in the head in tandem. Catra reacted immediately, driving her elbow back and catching Adora in the chest. Adora stumbled back, winded, then ducked as Catra tried to punch her. Then she lunged, tackling Catra. Her head snapped back as she hit the ground, and Adora winced. She hadn't meant to do that.

"Hey," she snapped at the boy as the clinic doors swung open. He fumbled as she threw the bat to him. "Just swing as hard as you can."

The *crack* that echoed through the air when he swung at the approaching clone was impressive.

Adora pinned Catra with one hand, producing a baseball with the other. "You are wasting your time." Her dull, monotone voice was grating on Adora's nerves. "Lord Prime will reign supreme."

"Not today," Adora snarled, forcing Catra to turn her head and bringing the baseball down right on the chip.

A burst of electricity consumed the chip for a moment, and Catra let out a brief scream before her entire body went slack.

"Let's go," she called to the boy as she stumbled up, hauling Catra onto her back. He hurried to catch up with her, clutching the bat to his chest. "Think you can keep up?"

"I… I'll try."

Good enough. Clones and chipped people were starting to flank them and close in; Adora turned slightly to drive through the crowd with her shoulder and saying, "Swing!"

Running with Catra on her back was hard, but Adora managed. Having the boy was surprisingly handy. She'd more or less had a plan to deal with this on her own, but the help was greatly appreciated. Especially since she was starting to crash by the time they got to the car.

"Can you drive?"

The boy looked at her, tripping slightly, but managing to keep up.

"I… Yeah?"

"Good. Car's about a mile up the road, get to it."

She dug through her hoody again, finding the EMP bomb she'd stolen and throwing it as hard as she could. It exploded against the ground in a burst of electricity, stopping their pursuers. Entrapta had modified her bombs a bit now after working with two chips, promising they would be more effective. Given the way some of the people dropped, Adora would say it would worked.

The boy was in the driver's seat, engine running, when Adora stumbled into the backseat, slamming the door. "Go."

"Where?"

"Doesn't matter, just drive!"

It definitely wasn't a *smooth* get away. Adora held Catra tight to her chest as they bounced around, because of course she hadn't thought to buckle up. Why waste the time?

"Sorry!" the boy apologized profusely, looking anxious in the rear-view mirror.

"It's fine, just keep going. Once we're clear, take us back to wherever you're staying." Adora grabbed the bag of supplies she'd left in the backseat, digging out the rope and blindfold. They were silent as she tied up Catra's wrists and ankles, and tied the cloth over her eyes. "Do you have a place?"

"Yeah," the boy said hesitantly. "My friends'll be mad if I bring you back, though."

"I'm not planning on trying to stay, don't worry. Just dropping you off. We've got a place." Hopefully. She got her tablet out next, turning it on and calling Glimmer. She picked up on the first ring.

"*Adora*!" Bow, Scorpia, and Perfuma immediately piled on top of her to see the screen as well. "*Are you okay?*"

"Yeah. I'm fine."

"*Good. Then what the FUCK is wrong with you?!*"

"*Glimmer*!" Angella's voice echoed faintly somewhere off screen.

"*No, I've earned this! You just* disappear *with one of the cars like we don't* all know *you're going to find Catra, do you have* any *idea how scared we've been?! What were you thinking? What if you got caught?*"

"*Did you get Catra?*" Scorpia inserted hopefully when Glimmer stopped to breathe. Adora relaxed slightly, smiling.

"I got her."

"*Wooooo*!" Scorpia yelled in delight, scooping Perfuma up and spinning her enthusiastically. "*We got Wildcat!*"

"*What about the chip?*" Bow asked. Adora rubbed the back of her head, grimacing.

"I uh… I hit it with baseball. And I've got her tied up and blindfolded so even if she wakes up, she won't be able to see

anything."

"*Still too dangerous to bring her back*," Glimmer said firmly. "*We'll meet you at the pharmacy.*"

"Okay, but hang on for a bit. I kinda rescued someone they were trying to chip, he needs to get back to his friends."

"It can wait," the boy said quickly. "This sounds more important."

Adora grabbed her phone to check where they were in relation to Bright Moon. "Where are your friends?"

"Thaymor."

She typed that in, eyes tracking the map. "It's only fifteen minutes out of the way from where I'm going. We'll get you home first."

"*And we'll see you in a bit*," Glimmer said shortly before hanging up.

"She sounds scary," the boy commented.

"She's mad. She should be. I kind of went rogue." Adora shook her head, sighing. "It doesn't matter. What's your name?"

"Oh — Kyle."

"Nice to meet you. I'm Adora. Though I guess you heard Glimmer screeching that."

He laughed nervously. "Yeah… think I'm glad I'm not going to meet her. Thanks for saving me, though."

Adora smiled, feeling good for just a moment. "I'm glad I could help."

Kyle was back with his friends, and Adora was about ten minutes out from Bright Moon when Catra groaned. "Ugh… What… What the fuck?"

Definitely Catra. Adora bit down a laugh. “Sorry, I know it’s kind of excessive, I just — I wasn’t sure if the chip would still be controlling you, and I needed to keep you from seeing where we’re going so it’d be harder to track us and — are you okay?”

“I feel like a dumbass rammed a baseball into the back of my neck,” Catra muttered blearily. She probably wasn’t fully awake. But she was awake enough to be mean. It was a start.

“What a weird way of saying ‘thanks for saving my life, Adora.’”

“Shut up.”

Glimmer and Bow were waiting outside the pharmacy. Adora kept her hands up until she was out of the car, and turned to show them her neck.

“Fine. Dad and Entrapta are waiting.”

Oh boy, she was *definitely* mad. Adora carefully pulled Catra out of the backseat, holding her close. She was only partially conscious, and mumbled some of an acknowledgment at the feeling of being moved.

“It’s okay,” Adora assured her. “Micah’s gonna give you something to help you sleep, and they’ll take the chip out. Everything’s going to be okay.”

For the first time in a long time, she believed that.

Chapter End Notes

Next Time: Catradora Fluff <3

Home For Now

Chapter Summary

Recovery and starting over

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Day One-Hundred Sixty-Three

Adora was half dozing as she laid beside Catra, but she immediately jerked awake when she felt her friend moving.

"Catra?"

"Mmmph," Catra mumbled eloquently, eyes struggling to open. She blinked heavily, trying to focus. "'Dora?"

"Yeah." Adora could have laughed. Or cried. Or kissed her. "Yeah, it's me. Hey."

"Hey." Her eyes slipped shut again. "You seen the idiot who hit me with a baseball? Gotta have words with her."

"Again, *weird* way of saying *thank you for saving my life*."

Catra hummed and shifted closer to curl up against Adora, resting her head on her shoulder. "Whatever."

Micah was… mostly certain that the stunt wouldn't have a permanent effect on Catra. But of course, there was no way to know until she was awake. Entrapta had been devastated at the state of the chip.

"*Saving Catra was more important, though,*" she'd added hastily.

"Hey 'Dora?"

Adora brushed her fingers through Catra's wild hair. "Hmm?"

"M'I crazy, or did I hear Trapta?"

"Both. It's a long story. I'll explain later. Scorpia's here too, so be prepared for that."

Catra groaned faintly, hiding her face in Adora's neck. "Going back to sleep now."

Day One-Hundred Sixty-Four

"Remember, she's probably going to be a little disoriented for a couple days. It's… a lot to come back from."

Slim, familiar fingers dragged themselves through Catra's hair. She was resting on something solid but comfortable, the thrum of a heartbeat under her ear.

"I know." The voice rumbled through her pillow. Adora, she realized, letting out a long, relieved breath. The idiot had run into an alien-infested city with a baseball bat to save her. That sounded about right. Catra grimaced, opening her eyes slightly, ready to give her friend a piece of her mind…

And then she saw the woman Adora was talking to.

She shrieked, jerking back and hitting the floor.

"Catra!"

Adora launched herself out of bed, grabbing Catra as she tried to scramble away. "Hey, it's okay, you're okay."

Catra shook her head furiously. Adora didn't *understand*. "She - She—"

The other woman's face fell. "Oh. Adora…"

"What?" Adora looked between them for a moment before realization lit up in her eyes. "*Oh*. No no no it's okay, we saved her

too. She's not chipped anymore. Neither of you are. It's okay."

She wrapped Catra in a tight hug. Catra clung back, hiding her face in Adora's neck. She didn't hear the other woman leave, but they were alone when she looked up again.

"*Mrow*."

Melog brushed against her leg, purring loudly. Catra laughed, startled. "Hey, buddy. You okay?"

"He's been getting *so* much attention. If he says otherwise, he's lying."

Catra looked back at Adora, smiling weakly. "Thanks for taking care of him."

Adora scoffed. "Like I was going to let anything happen to him. He's like, the most important thing in your life."

He definitely ranked up there. Catra curled into Adora again, shuddering slightly. Her head *hurt*. "You need some aspirin?" Adora guessed. Catra nodded, letting Adora help her back to bed. Melog joined her, pressing against her chest, still purring. She smile faintly, closing her eyes and scratching Melog's ears.

Day One-Hundred Sixty-Five

"Where are we?" Catra asked as she carefully sipped the water Adora had given her. She was getting a little more coherent with each day. It was a relief.

"Uh… it's complicated. Do you remember meeting those people from the Rebellion Twitter?" Catra nodded. "Their names are Glimmer and Bow. This is Glimmer's family's vacation house. It's pretty out in the middle of nowhere and apparently hidden well enough that it hasn't been found yet. There are escape plans though, just in case."

Catra rested her head on Adora's shoulder, letting out a long breath. "How um… How long has it been?"

"Awhile," Adora admitted. "Entrapta could probably give you an exact day count. She's figured out a way to track that somehow." She paused, carefully interlacing her fingers with Catra's. "She and Scorpia want to see you."

"Oh. Um…"

"You can take some time," Adora assured Catra as she went pale. "They understand."

Catra nodded, relaxing slightly, and curling closer to Adora. Adora held her close, gently lying both of them back down.

"Hey, Adora?"

"Yeah?"

"I love you."

The words were both surprising and not. Surprising because Adora certainly hadn't been expecting them *now*. Not surprising because… well, she knew.

"I… I don't expect anything," Catra said quickly, misinterpreting the silence completely. "And I don't want to make things weird, but I had a lot of time to think — kind of — I was like half-aware, and I kept thinking about *you* and if you were safe, and how stupid it was to waste so much time just because of my *mother*, and—"

She cut off as Adora held her a little tighter. "I love you too," she whispered. Catra let a long breath.

"Oh. Cool."

Day One-Hundred Sixty-Six

Catra was sleeping, so Adora took a moment to slip out of the room. She'd spent most of her time with Catra since they'd gotten back, and she really needed to stretch a bit.

"Adora."

Glimmer was standing right outside the door, arms crossed. Adora shut the door before Catra could be bothered — she had always been a light sleeper.

"I'm not apologizing," she said, shoving her hands into her pants pockets. "I mean, I'm sorry I worried all of you, but I'm not sorry I went after her."

"*Worried* us?" Glimmer repeated in disbelief. "You could've gotten us all killed!"

"I wasn't going to let them take me, Glimmer."

"And how would we ever know the difference? What if you just didn't come home? How would we know you weren't leading an entire army to us? We were making plans to jump ship, you know."

"Like I said, I'm sorry I scared you," Adora said through gritted teeth. "But I wasn't going to leave her there."

"No one suggested leaving her there! But this is the third time we've taken someone, and they're going to start noticing eventually. If we'd waited a little longer—"

"Then she could've been gone by the time we went back! We have *no idea* how any of this works, what… what *Prime* is thinking or how he moves people around. Catra was being used to round people up and bring them in to be chipped. What if they sent her somewhere more populated to make better use of her? How long was I supposed to wait?"

"More than a week and a half, maybe? We could've made a plan to go in *together*—"

"I didn't want to waste time! Besides, now we have three contacts closer to the city. If I hadn't gone when I did, Kyle would've been chipped, and they probably would've caught Lonnie and Rogelio too. I *saved* people. Isn't that what you want to be doing?"

"*Yes*, but not in a way that puts everyone else in danger!"

"Hey, *Sparkles*."

Adora turned, surprised, to see the bedroom door open. Catra was glaring at Glimmer, a little groggy, but mostly steady. "I get it, you're mad. Trust me, *everyone* knows. But do you *really* need to spend time sitting here obsessing over this and berating Adora? Because trust me, she's already done enough of that herself. She knows she fucked up, she doesn't need you to remind her. Don't you have something better to do?"

It was… probably not the *best* first impression. Glimmer opened and closed her mouth a couple times before saying, "Wow, you're *welcome* for saving you."

Catra's grip tightened on the doorknob. "*You* didn't do a god damn thing. Adora was the one who got me out of the city. Entrapta and your dad got the chip off. You don't get to sit there and act like I should be kissing your boots or some shit—"

"Okay," Adora said quickly, turning and pushing Catra back into the bedroom. "Glimmer, we'll talk later."

She shut the door before Glimmer could answer. "So you just hooked up with Sharon Weaver two-point-oh, huh?" Catra said through gritted teeth. Adora sighed.

"Glimmer is *not* like your mother, Catra."

"Coulda fucking fooled me. Acting like I should be *grateful* to her because, what? She hasn't thrown me out of the house yet? Fuck her."

It wasn't Glimmer's fault. Yeah, she was being kind of a jerk, but she didn't realize how much of an impact two words could have on a person. Especially two as innocuous as *you're welcome*.

Adora didn't say any of that, though. She just crossed the room, wrapping her arms tight around Catra and crushing her against her chest. She had never been able to protect Catra from her mother — she just picked up the pieces in the aftermath and tried to tape them back together. Now? Whatever her mother had done probably paled in comparison to what Catra had been through.

And Adora had no idea how to fix it.

Day One-Hundred Sixty-Seven

"Wildcat!"

Scorpia immediately threw her arms around Catra, beaming. Entrapta hung back in the door, rocking slightly on her heels, but smiling nonetheless. She wasn't a hugger. But was anyone really a hugger compared to Scorpia?

"Hey, big girl," Catra groaned, patting Scorpia on the back. "Glad you're safe. You too, Entrapta."

Entrapta's smile widened a bit. "Welcome back. I've been able to get some data off your chip even though Adora smashed it. It's been amazingly helpful."

"So glad to hear that."

"I'm soooooooo happy you're back!" Scorpia said, pulling back to look at Catra. "It didn't feel right without you around. And now you can meet my girlfriend! When you feel better, of course."

Melog *mrowl*-ed, jumping off the bed and going to inspect his food bowl. "Thanks for helping take care of him," Catra said, watching the cat go.

"No problem! We know how important he is. He was napping with Perfuma the other day, it was *adorable*. I got pictures, hang on…"

Adora leaned against the wall, watching her friends and smiling, Friends and girlfriend? They hadn't really talked about that. was it even important anymore? They knew they loved each other. That was all that matters. They didn't need to label it.

Even if it would make Adora *extremely* giddy to call Catra her girlfriend. This wasn't about her feelings.

Entrapta decided to join Scorpia and Catra on the bed, and Adora slipped out. She walked by Glimmer without a word, jogging down the stairs.

"It sounds like your friend is doing well," Angella said with a small smile as Adora made her way to the kitchen. The sound of happy, chattering voices was echoing through the house.

"Yeah. She's good at bouncing back from things." Adora hesitated before turning to look at Angella. "I know what I did was stupid —"

"Which is why I'm not lecturing you." Angella's voice was surprisingly patient. Glimmer definitely had not inherited her mother's personality. "You were foolish and reckless, but it's done. And four people are safer for it. There's no point in dwelling on what could have been." Adora nodded slowly. "That said, do *not* let it happen again. That's not a risk we can afford to take."

Adora blew out a long breath. "Yes, ma'am."

Day One-Hundred Sixty-Eight

"I think I felt my mom in there." Adora looked down at Catra, who was resting on her chest, staring at the wall. "It was like… like everyone was connected—"

"Spinnerella told us," Adora assured her, kissing the top of her head. Catra closed her eyes.

"It was hard, but sometimes I could pick out people I knew. They stood out to me in a way other people didn't. And I'm pretty sure my mom was there. And… And your parents."

That wasn't *really* a surprise, even if it felt like a swift kick to the gut. "I figured they were already gone," she said quietly, holding Catra closer.

"Still sucks."

"Yeah."

Catra wound her arms around Adora's waist, hugging her tight. "We saved you and Spinnerella," Adora said after a moment. "I think we're figuring things out."

"You can't really save the entire world, Adora," Catra said, lifting her head to give her a pointed look.

"Probably not," Adora agreed. "But I can save a few people. That makes a difference."

Catra was quiet for a moment, tucking herself back under Adora's chin. "Is it terrible that I don't care as long as you come home safe?" she asked quietly.

"No." Adora brushed her hands through Catra's hair. She was all Adora had cared about too, after all. Maybe it was a little selfish. But sometimes, that was okay.

Day One-Hundred Seventy

Catra was finally getting her first real look around the house, wide-eyed in shock. "This is—"

"Insane, right?" Adora said, squeezing her hand. "I can't believe we haven't been found yet."

"I can," Catra said distantly, looking around. "From what I could tell, they were focusing on places with heavier populations, since

that's the best way to find people. They haven't extended too far into wooded areas yet. I bet there are a lot of randos out there living off the grid totally safe. Unless they do something to really make themselves stand out, it'll be awhile before anyone even thinks to look for them."

"I'm pretty sure we're off the grid at this point," Adora said, looking back at Entrapta's little lab nook. "Entrapta had a theory they were using electricity use to track people. She's been working on generators."

"Smart move."

Netossa, Spinnerella, Micah, and Angella were sitting on the couches, talking in low voices. Spinnerella looked up for a moment to meet Catra's gaze, and they both looked away. "You okay?" Adora asked, squeezing Catra's hand.

"Yeah. It's just… I dunno, a little weird I guess."

"It's a lot," Adora agreed quietly. "They just vacation here, can you believe it?"

Catra snorted, rolling her eyes. "Must be nice having money."

Not that Catra's mother was poor in any way. But she had certainly never taken Catra anywhere for a *vacation*. Adora's parents had invited her on a camping trip, and Mrs. Weaver had reluctantly let her go. She and Adora had shared a tent and toasted marshmallows and snuck out after bedtime for adventures. It had been the best vacation of Adora's life.

Looking back, she wondered if her parents had known the truth about Mrs. Weaver and her abuse. They'd let Catra spend far more time over at their house than what was really normal. Adora had just thought she was really lucky to have such cool parents. But if they had known, why wouldn't they tell anyone? Or report her? Maybe they'd thought it was better to just take care of Catra as much as they could on their own.

Adora shook it off. It didn't matter now. It wasn't like she was ever going to get to ask.

"So we just live here now?" Catra asked curiously, following Adora to Entrapta's lab.

"Pretty much. Glimmer's been getting a little more antsy now that we have a way of getting the chips off."

"If you ever fight the clones, aim for the back of the neck. It's a weak point."

Adora nodded thoughtfully. "We need to get people better trained. You know, how to throw a punch and stuff."

"What, can everyone not just brute force their way through with a baseball and bat?"

"Very funny."

Day One-Hundred Seventy-Six

They were maybe a *little* paranoid.

Adora thought it was warranted, and no one argued. They had several cars stashed in different areas miles from the house, ready to take at a moment's notice in case they were flushed out. The keys were hidden in the car, and if someone found it and stole it, well… they probably needed it just as much. It was a risk they had to take.

"Seems dangerous," Catra said as they checked on one of the cars. They tried to do this every week or so, by Entrapta's time-keeping estimation.

"It's not the best system," Adora agreed with a shrug, ducking under the brush to check the car they had hidden there. "But at least we have an escape plan."

The car was safe, the stash untouched. Adora sent a text back to the house, letting them know. Catra swung her bat absentmindedly before resting it against her shoulder.

"Do you think we'll ever need this?" Catra asked as they started back toward the house.

"I hope not. But… who knows." Adora took Catra's hand absentmindedly. Catra blushed slightly; Adora pretended not to notice. "Can I ask you something?"

"You just did."

"Ha. Ha." Adora rolled her eyes. "That… That night… with the green light in your house." Catra shuddered, but nodded. "Was that the night they…?"

"Yeah." Catra's voice was rough. "It was just luck that they picked my house first instead of yours. But I'd found that rebellion twitter and they were interested in it. They wanted to use us to find it."

"Why'd they leave me unchipped?"

"Faulty logic?" Catra shrugged. "They don't really… understand humans. Apparently they've never found anything like us. Too much emotion or something."

She spoke in a forced neutral tone, eyes fixed on the sky. Adora took the hint and stopped asking questions.

Day One-Hundred Eighty

"We have over a hundred followers!" Glimmer said gleefully, practically jumping on top of Adora and jarring her awake. Catra immediately shot up, swinging blindly. Adora grabbed her arm to keep her from actually hitting Glimmer.

"What?"

Glimmer excitedly showed her the Twitter page. "The rebellion Twitter. People are following us! They're asking us questions, and want to help!"

"Be careful about who you meet in the middle of nowhere," Catra muttered into her pillow. Logically, Glimmer knew it wasn't Catra's fault that she had been chipped and tried to sell them out. But emotions weren't logical, and she was a little bitter.

Glimmer scoffed. "Yeah, I *know*. But we can still use Twitter to communicate. Even if they're watching it, there's nothing they can *do*. We're not giving away any identifying information. Everyone really wants to know more about removing the chips and how the people we've rescued are doing, though. Like if there's been any side effects or long term consequences or personality shifts or—?"

"I'm not doing your stupid Twitter thing," Catra said firmly.

"I wasn't *asking* you," Glimmer shot back crossly. "I'm just saying that people are interested."

"Congrats. Why are you in our bed?"

Glimmer huffed at her and rolled off Adora, walking out of the room. Things had been slightly tense, although Glimmer had gotten over the whole rescue thing. Adora had a feeling she was a little jealous, though. It was stupid and petty, but it felt normal. Adora was almost grateful for that. She needed normal.

"Am I crazy, or does Sparkles hate me?" Catra asked, turning her head to look at Adora.

"You're an acquired taste," Adora said with a small but smug grin. Catra rolled her eyes, flopping back down and rolling to nudge Adora with her shoulder.

"How long does it take to acquire me?"

"How long have we known each other?"

Melog jumped up to interrupt them with a loud meow — it was breakfast time, and that was everyone's problem.

"Okay, okay…"

They got up, getting dressed and ready for the day. Catra grabbed Adora's hand before she could leave, though, tugging her closer.

"What—"

Catra got on her tiptoes and pressed a kiss to Adora's lips. "Figured a little more acquiring wouldn't hurt."

That was so stupid, and Adora laughed. She was definitely in love.

Melog's bowl was in their bedroom, so they left him to his meal, making their way downstairs. Perfuma and Scorpia were just making their way up from the basement, where Perfuma had started a garden. It was slow going, especially since they had to make due with the souped-up sun lamps Entrapta had made, but Perfuma assured them it would be worth it to have fresh vegetables. That was probably good for them, considering all factors that were against their health.

They split the rest of the box of cereal, sitting at the kitchen island and watching the shadows of the trees outside. "Do you think we'll ever see the sun again?" Catra asked after a moment.

"I hope so," Adora said quietly. She couldn't imagine the rest of their lives without *any* sunlight. How were they supposed to live like this?

"There has to be a way to get the sun back," Glimmer declared, startling them both.

"How does she *do* that?" Catra hissed to Adora, who shrugged. She just assumed Glimmer was small and could get around easily. Catra also had a bad habit of appearing out of nowhere and startling her, too.

"Is fighting really the right thing to do?" Perfuma asked uncertainly. "We're lucky, and we have a good thing here."

"Of course we should fight!" Glimmer protested. "We can't just roll over and die for them."

"No one is talking about dying," Perfuma said. "But looking for a fight is dangerous. That's not something we should invite on ourselves."

"Doing nothing is basically the same thing."

Catra threw back a handful of dry cereal, crunching loudly. Adora shot her small smile, kicking her shin. She'd always been such a heathen about eating her cereal *dry*. She was lactose intolerant, but that didn't stop her from eating things like pizza or cheesecake. But it was all dramatics when it came to milk in cereal.

"No offense, Sparkles, but they're an alien empire. What do you think *we* can do?"

"Something. Anything!" Glimmer said, turning to Catra. "You can't seriously say you're okay with just standing around and letting all of this happen."

Catra made an annoyed noise in the back of her throat. "No, I'm not *okay* with a bunch of mind-controlling aliens and their hostile, systematic takeover of our planet. But we're like, four adults and seven teenagers with a bunch of random weapons. And I'm taking my baseball bat back," she added to Adora. "Your form sucks."

"Rude."

"Then why shouldn't we try to do anything?" Glimmer challenged. "If we don't try, nothing is going to change."

"Are you listening?" Catra asked, irritated. "There is *nothing* we can do except try to survive and help other people do the same. This isn't a movie. We're not some weird underdogs who are

going to save the day. If we can *live*, call that a victory and don't ask for more."

"Watch me," Glimmer shot back. Bow was coming down the stairs just in time to hear the tail-end of the argument, and jumped down the last few steps, grabbing Glimmer by the shoulder.

"Come on, let's get some air," he said cheerfully, tugging her to the door. Adora shoveled down the rest of her cereal, giving Catra a quick smile, and hurrying after them.

"Ugh!" Glimmer kicked a tree, clearly frustrated. "Why am I the only one who cares about this?!"

"You're not," Bow assured her. "But it's… hard to think about what we can really do. Right now, surviving *should* be our top priority. We can't help anyone else if we can't help ourselves, right?"

"But we *can* help people. We already know so much more than we did before all this started—"

"And you're doing what you can with social media," Adora said. "We can't go into a full-on fight with a bunch of aliens and mind-controlled people, but Catra was right. We can still help other people live. That's still worth a lot."

Glimmer deflated a little, but nodded. "Yeah. Fine. I guess." She kicked the tree again. "I hate this."

Bow wrapped her gentle hug, which Adora joined. "And we've already done so much good, you know? We saved two people, and figured out how to get the chips off. That's *really* important. It could save the world someday."

"Yeah," Glimmer muttered again. But she clung tight to them, pressing her face into Bow's shoulder.

Catra was back upstairs when Adora went looking for her, lying on their bed and playing with Melog. "Hey." Adora sat on the edge of

the bed, smiling. Catra didn't smile back. Melog latched onto her hand, gnawing on her fingers. "You okay?"

"Is Sparkles done with her freaking temper tantrum?"

Adora sighed. "I know she's a lot—"

"She's a *brat*." Catra rolled onto her side, letting Melog continue chewing on her hand. "Seriously, what the fuck, Adora?"

"She's passionate. And it's hard to feel helpless." Adora took the hand that wasn't being used as a chew toy and squeezed. "All I wanted to do the entire time you were gone was find you and save you. You know I suck at sitting still."

"Oh trust me, I know." Catra rolled her eyes. "I was the one sitting on you in the dugout between turns, remember?"

"I could've fielded!"

"You were dehydrated!"

They laughed, and Catra finally detached her hand from Melog to sit up, scooting closer to Adora and resting her head on Adora's shoulder. Adora wrapped her arms around Catra, tugging her into her lap.

Day One-Hundred Eighty-Three

Adora startled awake when she felt Catra thrashing next to her. "Catra?" She shook Catra's shoulder. "Hey, Catra, wake up."

She shot up with a gasp, still half-asleep as she grasped at the back of her neck. "You're okay," Adora assured her, squeezing Catra's shoulder and trying to ground her. "You're okay. It's okay."

Catra gasped out a few breaths, a hand grabbing Adora's arm. Melog crawled into her lap, purring loudly. "You're okay," Adora said again, hugging her tight. "They can't hurt you."

"Yes they can." Catra's voice was hoarse and shaky. "They can always hurt me."

Adora pulled her a little closer, kissing the top of her head. She wasn't wrong — none of them were *really* safe. But that wouldn't stop Adora from doing everything she could to protect Catra.

No matter what.

Day One-Hundred Ninety

Looking back, the moment before everything went to hell felt surreal. Entrapta was talking about some new projects she was working on while Bow listened, enraptured, and Scorpia tried to look like she knew what was going on. There were little conversations going on here and there.

And then sickening green light flooded the room.

Glass walls. Not a great idea.

The light burned Adora's eyes. Everyone went still for a moment until their eyes adjusted, and they saw figures in the light.

Someone screamed, "*Run*!" Adora didn't know who, but it spurred her into action; she threw herself up the stairs, bolting for the bedroom. Catra was awake, staring at the green light in horror while Melog hissed and snarled. Adora grabbed his carrier and shoved him in, ignoring the teeth in her hand.

"Catra, come on!"

She didn't move. She was still staring out the window. Adora grabbed the bat from the side of the bed, tugging at Catra's arm. Glass shattered downstairs. Adora practically lifted Catra off the bed, throwing Melog's carrier at her. That seemed to shake her out of her trance.

Downstairs had descended into chaos. A small, experimental robot army was trying to attack the clones while Bow fumbled to grab

an arrow and knocked it into place. Scorpia was doing her best to cover Perfuma and Entrapta. Spinnerella was trying to pull Netossa away, while Angella did the same with Micah. Glimmer had grabbed the kitchen knife set and was throwing them with surprisingly accuracy. Adora dropped Catra's arm and swung as hard as she could at the closest clone. The sound of its skull cracking was surprisingly cathartic.

"Everyone, get out!" Micah yelled. They were clearly outnumbered. And escaping was more important than standing their ground.

"Trade." Catra grabbed the bat and threw Melog at Adora in one swift move and — okay, *fine*, she was way better with the bat than Adora was. There was a sort of grace to how she swung it, hitting a clone so hard that she knocked it into a window. Adora hooked Melog's carrier over her shoulder and braced herself to brute force their way through. The clones clearly hadn't been expecting *this much* resistance; they were too easy to catch off guard, and Adora played a little dirty, using elbows and knees for extra *oomf*.

Adora grabbed Catra's hand as soon as they were free. And they ran.

They ran until the green light faded, until Adora almost ran into a tree because she couldn't see, until they were breathing hard and their sides hurt.

"Are… you… okay?" Adora gasped, doubling over to rest her hands on her knees.

"Yeah. I'm… fine." Catra grabbed Melog's carrier, ignoring his howling, and dug out a small mag light, turning it on. "Turn around."

Adora would've rather fallen over, but she complied. Apparently it would've been easy for a clone to just slap a chip on her neck.

Catra made sure she was clean, and she turned to let Adora see her own unmarred neck.

"Now what?" she asked quietly as she turned back to meet Adora's gaze. It was a good question. Adora cast a desperate look around the woods, trying to figure out where they were. There was probably a car close by, but she was completely out of sorts.

"Let's just… walk. This way."

They kept their fingers intertwined as they walked. Melog eventually calmed down. "We don't have any food for him," Catra said.

"We'll find a grocery store or something," Adora assured her. "I bet pet food isn't in high demand."

"Yeah." Catra did her best to look a little more optimistic. "You're right."

They found their way eventually, and had to stop themselves from running to the nearest car. They had to make sure no one was waiting to ambush them first. Catra readied the bat, hard-eyed.

"I'll drive first."

She stepped toward the car, looking around to make sure no one was approaching. She signaled for Adora to join her when she had cleared the car. Adora walked forward warily, glad that Catra had offered to drive first. She was exhausted.

The car had barely started before her eyes slipped shut, and she held Melog's carrier close as she fell asleep.

Day Unknown

They took turns driving. Time lost all meaning as they drove through the never-ending night. Eventually they came across a small gas station, and found some cat food in the weird grocery area in the back. It wasn't perfect, but it would keep Melog fed.

The cat was more than happy to scarf it all down. Catra sat in the back with him while Adora drove, tapping away on the tablet.

“Anything?” Adora asked. Catra shook her head.

“Maybe they haven’t tried calling around yet,” she said slowly, still staring at the screen. “Take the next left.”

“What? Why?”

“I have an idea. Take a left.”

Adora did as she was told, following all of Catra’s directions. Catra leaned forward to watch the road. “There,” she finally said, pointing to a small used car lot.

“You want a new car?”

“Nope. I want to upgrade. Go around back.”

There were a couple RVs in the back lot. They pulled to a stop, and Catra grabbed the bat, hopping out. Adora followed a little slower, watching Catra test the door of the first RV.

“Sweet,” she said when it opened. She peeked in, scanning to make sure no one else was there before stepping in. “Oooooooh. Adora, come check this out.”

Adora grabbed Melog just in case and followed Catra to the RV. It was surprisingly spacious — there was a small table with a bench against the wall, a sink across from that, and a mini stove beside that. The counters and tables were fake marble, the floor linoleum. Down to the left was large bed, to the right was the cabin, with a bed over it.

“Not too shabby,” Catra said, looking back at Adora. “And they use diesel, which is probably way easier to find than regular gas now.”

It would mean leaving the car. But they were going to run out of gas eventually, and then what? At least this offered a little more

shelter.

“Let’s find the keys.”

The office was small, thankfully, and there were only three RVs — they took all the keys back and tested them until one worked. They had half a tank of gas, and Adora was pretty sure she’d seen a gas station down the street so they could try to fill up. Catra tossed the other keys back into the office, and helped Adora transfer their belongings to their new home.

“Neither of us has ever driven anything this big,” Adora pointed out. Catra flopped onto the bed, patting Melog’s carrier.

“Try not to crash.”

“Wow, thanks.” Adora slid into the driver’s seat, taking a deep breath. “Where to next?”

“Wherever we think the others might be.” Catra sat up, grabbing the tablet. “Maybe head toward Bright Moon?”

Adora nodded, carefully pulling out of the parking lot. It wasn’t too bad once she relaxed and let herself settle in. “Bright Moon it is.”

They stopped a few miles down the road at the gas station to fill up, which took a hot minute to figure things out, but eventually they were pumping gas into the RV. Catra grabbed a couple of their empty gas cans to fill up with diesel, then broke into the gated storage where the propane tanks were kept. They were so busy, they almost missed the tablet ringing.

“Fuck!” Catra nearly dropped the propane tank she was struggling with and threw the RV door open, running to where she’d left the tablet. She opened the window for Adora to hear as she answered. “Necks.”

“*You first*.” Adora perked up. It was Glimmer.

"Adora's putting gas in the RV, we can show you when she's done. You guys first."

"*Here*." Glimmer squawked, presumably as Bow took the tablet. Adora hurriedly finished and ran back inside. She all but tackled Catra to see the screen.

"Guys!"

Bow finished showing off Glimmer's neck, and she immediately grabbed the tablet back. "*Are you guys okay? Have you seen anyone else?"*

"No," Adora said with a sigh. "You?"

They shook their heads. "*It'll be okay,*" Bow said with forced optimism. "*We'll find them. Where are you guys?*"

"*Wait, did you say Adora was filling the RV?*"

"Yeah, we got a new place." Catra flipped the camera to show them their home. "Pretty sweet, right?"

"*Awesome*," Bow breathed. "*That's a* great *idea. Glimmer, we should get an RV!*"

"*We'll work on that. Where can we meet you guys?*"

Catra pulled up the map. "Salineas. We could go on a beach vacation. Not a great time for sunbathing, though."

"*Salineas. Awesome. We'll meet you there. Stay safe*."

"You too, Sparkles. Arrow Boy." Bow saluted, and they ended the call. Catra exchanged a smile with Adora.

"To Salineas?"

"To Salineas."

Adora made her way back to the driver’s seat. Catra finally released Melog, who immediately curled up in the middle of the bed, and went to sit in the passenger’s seat. The road was pitch black and ominous, no end in sight.

But they had each other. They would get through this somehow. They could get through anything as they were together.

Chapter End Notes

"WAIT BUT WHAT ABOUT-"

Nope, nooooooooooope. I know there's a ton of open plot points, but I really like the idea of an open ending. If anyone wants to pick up and write more, feel free! Just link the OG story. I'd love to see more takes on this universe, I'm just not up for writing an extended story.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!